

BOOK TWO
TEMPTATIONS



Devil
IN THE **WATERS**

KT MORRISON

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Devil In The Waters

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About the Author

KT Morrison writes stories about women who fall in love with sexy men who aren't their husband, and loving relationships that go too far—couples who open a mysterious door, then struggle to get it closed as trouble pushes through the threshold.

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All characters are over the age of eighteen.

TEMPTATIONS

A Devil In The Waters Novella

Book 2

39,500 words

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Written by KT Morrison

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Introduction

A few months ago I began a Patreon. It's a website where creators can garner support from their fans who wish to be patrons.

The aim of my Patreon is to help support the quicker finishing of series' I have still left hanging, and in return I offer a frequent-update series appearing first on Patreon where all the patrons analyze and debate every character's actions and motivations—it's grown to a great and active little community . . .

for more info:

ktmorrison.com

I

Tuesday, July 14

Dark Roast

On Tuesday, as luck would have it, Josh was sent out of the office and into Toronto with two other managers for a scheduled meeting with three executives from Forefront, a product placement company that was growing fast and wanted more and more data. Forefront already signed a contract with Swanson, and now they wanted streamlined logistics and delivery sequenced just for them. The meeting was straightforward—a bunch of nothing at the table, and a shitload of to-dos in the coming week, but he was excited to take the opportunity of being in the city to track down Amy who should still be in the country and staying at the nearby Four Seasons.

He'd gone to the meeting with Rita and that idiot, Rafe, taking Rafe's car, his stupid Charger in all its aftermarket glory. Rafe'd cranked some type of dumb techno music the whole way from Ajax to Toronto, and if he wasn't going to be able to meet Amy after the meeting, he'd like to come up with some other way to get out of returning to Ajax with Rafe and his music. So after the meeting he told Rita he was going to bail for the afternoon, it was late anyway, and he'd catch a train back to Ajax early evening, take an Uber to the office to get his car. They said bye, and he tried tracking Amy down, starting on Facebook. Didn't find her there, but was lucky enough to know her Instagram, saw that she had posted this morning a picture of the vintage art deco neon sign of the Senator Diner, #TripHome, her comment saying Visit to the TDot & lunch today with an old friend.

It was one o'clock, so that's where he headed.

Off the subway and in the complex below the Eaton Center, he sent Amy a message on Facebook saying You had lunch at the Senator?

It took a full ten minutes—and he thought he'd be heading home without a meeting—but Amy got back to him. She sent a thumbs up.

The vague reply wasn't much to go on, but he messaged Fancy a coffee at the Artisan Bean?—I'm buying which was where he was sitting right now, waiting . . .

Amy showed up twenty minutes later, coming across the coffee shop's patio dressed in tight, intimidating clothing. In high school Amy'd been serious, and now she was some bigwig executive in London, she'd become downright steely. Her no-nonsense form strutted the broad concrete flagstones in a black suit and skirt combo, four-inch heels, legs bare, muscles flexing. She'd shorn her hair, cut it to a severe bob now, changing its gingery color to a pure white-blonde.

Josh had picked a spot at the counter that stretched the coffee shop's window, perched on a stool, one reserved next to him for Amy since the place was busy today. He waved at her through the glass, but she ignored him—reflection and the brightness, probably showed her only her own face. He greeted her when she came in, and she hugged him lightly.

“Josh, darling,” she said, “glad to see you upright.”

He groaned, rolled his eyes. “Probably why I wanted to meet you.”

She said, “I'm not looking to get drunk today, dear,” and patted him on the waist, slipping past him to get in line for a coffee. He scooped his from the bar and joined her in the line. He said, “I have a spot over there, is that all right?” His jacket over the stool still reserved his spot.

“At the window? No, I'm not sitting at the window, there's a booth at the back, get that one.”

“I said I'd buy you a coffee . . .”

“I can buy my own coffee, get the booth before it's gone.”

He brought his coffee to the back of the busy shop, saw there was indeed a vacant setting, and he slipped into the booth and waited. Amy came to the table with a cappuccino on a saucer. She said, “So what’s this about needing to talk to me?”

He sipped his coffee, said, “Not needing. Wanting. About the party . . . ?”

“What about it?” She indexed through the sugar packets in a square bowl on the table, selecting none of them, sipping at her cappuccino.

“I was in the city today for a meeting, and I was just killing time afterward, I saw you post where you were, thought I’d take a chance, see if you’d have a coffee with me.”

“Here we are,” she said, tipping her cup to him in salute before taking another sip. “The coffee in this city is shit.”

He said, “All the beans come from the same place, no matter where they serve it . . .”

“Everybody here just wants an angle, Josh, trying to make a dollar, nobody’s actually trying to make a good cup of coffee.”

“Some do.”

“You come to this place?” she said.

“No, never been—this is the closest good coffee shop. It’s supposed to be popular . . .”

“It’s all right,” she said, sipping, “just not what I’m used to.”

“How is England?” he said, “capital of fine coffee . . .”

“You’re such an asshole,” she said and laughed.

“You’re the asshole, shitting on my country’s coffee.”

“It’s my country too,” she said, eyes narrowed slyly.

“So you’re happy in London?”

“I always thought I’d come back here after uni, now I can’t imagine leaving London.”

“How is work going?”

Amy told him all about life in London, working in the Canary Wharf, and what she did there; managing the legalities for the St. James Gallery, plus legal consulting work. Not bad at twenty-seven years old. She asked him again why he wanted to talk to her.

“I suppose I expect I need to apologize . . .”

She smirked, swirled the remaining foamy mixture in the bottom of her cappuccino cup. “How so?”

“You know, for my behavior at the party . . .”

“And what did you do for which you need to apologize?”

He said, “You don’t think I need to apologize? Look . . . Kimmy told me . . .” He let it hang, fishing.

She didn’t bite. “Kimmy told you what?”

“About, you know . . .”

“For that? You should apologize for that?”

“I’m sorry.”

She frowned and leaned closer, whispered, “For the peeing thing?”

He licked his upper lip, stomach turned. A toehold on the truth of what happened, but not what he’d expected. “Yeah,” he said, “I thought I should apologize.”

“Don’t worry about it. I’ve helped a lot of guys pee.”

His stomach and scalp tightened, and he held his breath a moment. Helped him pee? He joked: “That’s something to brag about?”

She laughed politely, drained her coffee cup then wiped her mouth with a napkin, looking to get out of here.

He said, “What do you mean you helped me pee—Kimmy didn’t tell me that part . . .”

“We helped you, Josh, we,” she said. “Kimmy and I had to get your pants down, it took you forever to get it going . . .”

“It took me forever to get what going—pee?”

She wagged both her hands, quitting the conversation, and looked away, smiling, expression like this was the last thing she wanted to talk about.

“I didn’t know that,” he said quiet and morose.

“Then what did you want to apologize for?”

“For getting drunk,” he said. Then: “You helped take my pants down?”

“Josh, you don’t need to apologize. I went to uni in Glasgow, I work in London. Not exactly a culture of teetotalers.”

His mouth hung open, a question hanging in the air. “Did you see . . . my . . . ?”

He didn’t even need to finish it. She said, “Josh, the last thing I want to do today is talk about your penis. It’s not what I thought of this morning, it’s definitely not what I want to think of for the rest of the afternoon.”

He tried to be light: “I don’t know if that’s a compliment or not.”

“It’s not,” she said firmly, smiling still but tossing her napkin down on the table between them. “This was nice, thanks for calling me out for coffee, Josh.”

“You have to go?”

“I do, it’s crazy—coming back to Canada I didn’t think I’d be so busy, but everybody wants a piece of me. Now I have to go see my aunt and uncle out in Mississauga, God help me, my cousins tomorrow, friends to see up in Newmarket, then I’m on a plane on Thursday . . .”

“Thanks for your time though . . . but . . .”

Amy was checking to make sure she had her phone, wallet, purse, anything else she might leave behind. “But what?”

He said, “What happened with Kimmy? You know, after I passed out . . .”

“What did she tell you?” Amy said without looking up.

“That she got in a fight with Devlin.”

“That is exactly what happened.”

“Over what?”

“What did she tell you?”

“Politics.”

“That’s exactly what it was about,” she said, putting her Hermès bag on the table, resting her hands overtop and looking in his eyes now. “If you want to know what happened, ask Kimmy. Not me.”

“So nothing happened?”

“It’s just what Kimmy said.”

“Now you’re making me think it’s a lot more than that.”

“Why?”

“You’re saying that whatever she told me is right—you’re her friend who’s just going to back up whatever she says. You wouldn’t tell me the truth.”

“You don’t trust me to tell you the truth?”

“That’s not what I said.”

“That’s totally what you said, Josh, kind of surprising really.”

“What do you mean surprising?”

“Thought you guys had respect for each other.”

“Don’t pull that with me.”

“You don’t trust her?”

“I trust her,” he said.

She flashed a satisfied smirk. “Then why are you here?”

“You’re right,” he said, trying to save face now. “I’m just worried Devlin put his hands on her and she’s afraid to tell me.”

“Why? What would you do?”

“I don’t know. But I would have to do something, right?”

She shrugged, said, “Beats me, I was lucky enough to be born with a vagina.”

“Here, here,” he said, and saluted her with his coffee cup now. “To vaginas.”

“Droll, Josh,” she said, grimacing like his remark was distasteful.

She rose to stand, and he followed suit. They embraced awkwardly, he told her he’d say bye to Kimmy for her, she kissed the air near both of his cheeks, patted his back.

She said, “Talk to Kimmy, don’t go behind her back.”

“I didn’t,” he said, but even the sound of the words coming out of his mouth—and the guilty expression he knew was on his face—made him a liar. He’d tried to go behind her back. “Safe flight,” he said then, and she waved, strutted to the front door, heels brightly clicking on the marble floor.



There’d been a takeout menu that arrived in the mail today from a new place she thought she and Josh might like to try, a Brazilian rodízio, a steakhouse with a liquor license, and they had delivery options as well, though not all-you-can-eat. All that remained of the paper mailer were the curled strips she’d torn it into and arranged on her worktable in a nervous heap.

When her phone rang she snatched it up. Amy said, “Hello?”

“What happened?”

Amy said, “I dealt with it.”

“What did he want?”

“What do you think?”

She groaned, rubbed her forehead and closed her eyes, hunched her back over her worktable. She said, “What did he want to know?”

“Wanted to know what happened between you and Devlin.”

Jesus, she sighed. “What did you tell him?”

“I told him to ask you.”

“He already asked me.”

Amy said, “Why won’t you tell him?”

The question was ludicrous, and she laughed at the thought of sitting down with Josh and telling him all that had been going on. Her voice whined: “Are you kidding me?”

“I mean make up a lie, Kimmy. Sounded to me like you wouldn’t tell him anything. If Josh wants to know, tell him a story that makes sense, makes him feel better, and most importantly: stop snooping into your friends.”

“I’m sorry he called you.”

There was a quiet moment, both of them saying nothing, the sound of Amy’s fabric rustling, the background white noise whoosh of a subway station. Amy said, “He reeked of fear. It radiated from him.”

She groaned deeply, palmed her forehead. “Don’t say that.”

“Let him off the hook, Kimmy. You’ve got your poor man all twisted.”

“What am I going to tell him?”

“You know the best way to not talk about something? Tell them what they want to hear. You and Devlin argued about politics. That’s what Josh believes, so tell him that, tell him exactly what you argued about. Paint Devlin the way Josh sees him, he’ll sleep better at night.”

“I did.”

“It’s obviously not enough. Fill in the blanks for him.”

“Oh my God,” she sighed, “I can’t believe this.”

“Don’t worry, he doesn’t know anything . . .”

Amy didn’t even know the situation had got worse since Tiffany’s party. Amy didn’t even know her friend Kimmy had even more to lie about. “Did

you tell anybody?”

Another long pause. “Who am I going to tell?”

“I don’t know, there are plenty of people . . . please, just tell me you didn’t tell anybody.”

“I didn’t tell anybody.”

“Is this one of those times you just tell someone what they want to hear?”

Amy laughed away from her phone. When she came back she said, “It could be. But it’s not. I didn’t tell anybody.”

She gathered up the shredded mailer, scooping it off her worktable and into the cup of a palm, phone tucked against her shoulder. She got up and tossed the strips into the wastebasket, went to the window and leaned against the sill, looking out at the sunny day. “I can’t believe I could do this to Josh.”

“Don’t blame yourself.”

She chuckled, pushed thumb and finger into her shut-tight eyes. “Who else am I going to blame?”

“I don’t know,” Amy said, but her tone implied she thought it was obvious but didn’t want to say. Did she mean Josh? Did she mean Devlin?

She let it go, said nothing. It was her fault, there was no one else to blame.

Amy said, “You told Josh about helping him to pee?”

“No,” she groaned into an arm. She’d rested her cheek on her folded wrists.

“Well he knew all about it, was asking me . . .”

“Oh, yeah—I just told him that he had to pee.”

“That’s all you told him?”

She worked her mouth around, a ball of acid threatening her esophagus.
“Yeah . . .”

“Don’t tell him any of that.”

She sighed heavily, her heart sinking in her chest. A wave of guilt and shame had splashed up her shore, and she rubbed the back of her neck.
“Amy . . .”

Amy waited to hear what she would say, but when she was quiet too long, prompted, “What is it, love?”

“I made it . . . since the party, I made it worse . . .”

“Made it worse how?”

She squeezed her nose. Her feet went tingly. She straightened, cocked her head and watched a flock of geese cross east to west over top the Ajax rooflines. “I met with . . . Devlin came by my apartment when Josh wasn’t home . . .”

Amy exploded in breathy chuckles away from her phone. A train roared into her station; an announcement was made over a speaker system. Amy’s heels clicked on subway tile and Kimmy listened as her friend got herself somewhere quieter. Amy said, “Oh no you didn’t.” Her friend was buoyant with disbelieving glee.

“I did, Amy.”

Amy moaned with unmistakable lechery. “Oh, Kimmy, Kimmy . . . tell me everything . . .”

Brewing

It took two-and-a-half hours on the train and subway to get back to Ajax. Twenty minutes to get to Swanson, fifteen to get home. While he was walking in the apartment door a few minutes earlier than if he'd just been coming home from the office on a normal work day, he felt heavy, dragging his feet as if he'd walked all the way back from Toronto.

No lights were on and at first he thought Kimmy wasn't home. The apartment was bright, but the sunlight this time of year was coming from the other side of the building, making their home seem dim. Kimmy had been sitting on the couch, and she rose now, came around to meet him.

"Is the power out?"

She said it wasn't, frowning.

"No lights are on, you're sitting on the couch with the TV off . . ."

"I was waiting for you," she said.

"For what?"

Kimmy stopped, put a hand on the wall to steady herself as she slipped her feet into leather ballerina flats. He watched her skinny and shapely legs work below the hem of her army green shorts. She said, "Let me buy you a beer."

There was something odd about the statement. Part of it was never in his almost nine years of dating-plus-marriage with his Kimmy had she ever greeted him coming home by offering to buy him a beer. And there was a

certain camaraderie in buying someone a beer, and oftentimes a sentiment of lessening a blow, or helping someone delivered bad news.

He asked, “Is everything okay?”

“Yeah,” she said, drawing down a droopy cotton cardigan to drape over her narrow shoulders, bare in her black spaghetti strap top.

“I don’t really feel like I want a beer.”

“Let’s go out.”

“I don’t think I’m ready for a beer.” He intended because his body was still in recovery from Tiffany’s party and not prepared to wage even a minor skirmish against alcohol right now. But there was dread rising up inside him, and the truth was he wasn’t ready for bad news of any kind. “Can we just stay in?”

“Please, Josh,” she said, shrugging on the cardigan.

“I spent the whole afternoon traveling, I just want to relax now I’m home . . .”

“One beer, Josh.”

“Don’t we have beer here?”

She passed him back the keys to the Nissan. They did have beer in the fridge. Kimmy wanted to go out somewhere public, somewhere her husband wouldn’t make a scene . . .

In the car, his hands went cold on the wheel and he didn’t press Kimmy on the reason she wanted to get out of the house. He let her tell him how she was just cooped up in the apartment and she needed to get out. She’d skipped the gym the other day, he figured, and hoped there was truth to it. But he couldn’t shake the feeling there was a deep talk coming between husband and wife entering strange and shaky marital ground.

By the time he parked out front of The Fox and Dragon, just down the street from them in old Ajax, he knew what it was. Amy'd talked to Kimmy.

The Fox and Dragon was an English style pub in a conglomerate of imitation Tudor-style English homes made to look like they were from the countryside; red brick first floors, stucco and square beam on the second floor. Kimmy and he bypassed the front doors, instead entering under the brick archway that led to the pub's patio, sequestered in a courtyard faced by boutique shopping that had run dry of customers a decade ago, the once luxury brands now replaced with more moderate hair salons and casual clothes shops. There was a step up to the Dragon's raised patio, its edges lined with iron railing painted black and hung with Jamesons pennants. There were only a handful of tables in use out of the fifteen, and Kimmy aimed for the one furthest from any other patrons, sitting down with a leg tucked beneath her under the shade of a huge black Guinness umbrella popped open overhead. Josh waved to a waitress headed back inside to make sure they were acknowledged and the girl smiled swishing back inside, ponytail bobbing. He sat down opposite Kimmy, chair pulled out from the table so they were practically facing each other. He assumed a pose he usually held when on the toilet—back hunched, elbows on knees, hands clasped together in front of him.

He said, "So what's up?"

"It's nice to come out, don't you think?"

There was positivity in her tone, but he could read the trouble in her own eyes. When he registered it in her gaze, she saw him process it. Now they both knew.

He said, "Just tell me what's up."

"You met with Amy today."

"Amy called you?"

Kimmy nodded, her expression held solemn as she studied him.

“I met her for coffee.”

“For coffee, Josh? Come on . . .”

He rubbed his chin and let Kimmy’s dark eyes stare into him, her steady gaze unnerving. When Kimmy was happy, she had a fun beauty. She was quick to smile, and she had a pretty mouth. Between her knowing eyes and her smile it was a toss up for her greatest physical feature. A smile on Kimmy’s face did something profound to him that was impossible to translate. It manifested in a weird personal joy—like your face was a mirror held up to hers, or her happiness shone into you; and there was something deeper, too, like an appreciation. An appreciation the way someone open to art would feel standing before a powerful masterpiece and seeing in it, finally in person, what they believed was the artist’s truth. But there was also the obverse, and though it was rare, this stony look from his beautiful wife brought out her exotic darkness, and the effect was chilling. Kimmy became unreadable.

“Maybe I embarrassed myself,” he said, looking down at her bare knees.

The answer seemed to surprise her because she raised her eyebrows and cocked her head.

The waitress strode toward them, smiling while she armed herself with a notepad and pen. “Can I get you guys a drink to start?”

Kimmy’s mouth eased. She looked to him saying, “Have a beer with me, Josh.”

He gave in, and they both ordered a pint of Newcastle and the waitress checked on her other tables before heading back inside.

“Amy called me.”

“I should have figured.”

“What were you thinking?”

“It seemed like it was a reasonable thing to do—meet with one of your friends. I . . . knew I wanted to talk about Tiffany’s. I didn’t think . . . I’d sound so obsessed or whatever.”

Kimmy drew in a long breath, looking at some of the other patrons, crossed her arms and leaned back. “What do you suspect?”

Her question made him feel foolish. He said, “I suspect there’s something you don’t want to tell me. And that’s scaring me.”

She nodded and he was pleased to see it as a communication of agreement. She looked forlorn a moment, watching away from him again. “I should have told you . . .”



An imaginary itch had her nails scratching at the palm of her hand. Amy was right. A Josh kept in the dark was an unhappy Josh. She didn’t want him to hurt.

He said, “Are you going to tell me?”

“Yeah,” she said, “I will,” but looked around to the door into the restaurant. “Just wait,” she said to Josh, who sat slump-shouldered in his wrinkled dress shirt with the cuffs rolled up. He’d doffed his tie in the apartment, then left his jacket in the Nissan. His body’s energy radiated defeat, his eyes showed angst. She said, “It’s not bad, Josh, it’s just stupid. And embarrassing.”

“Tell me . . .”

This time when she looked around she saw the waitress coming through the doors with two brown ales on a tray.

She returned to face Josh, showed him a weak smile saying, “I didn’t want her to walk in on what I have to say.”

Josh looked sickly as the waitress came and set their glasses on cardboard coasters beside them. The girl asked them if they wanted anything to eat and she said not yet. The waitress left, and she held up her glass to Josh and they both toasted like their ales weighed twenty pounds. They sipped.

The apartment was the more appropriate place to spin an almost-truthful tale of the party at Tiffany’s but as she’d prepared in her mind how she’d present the case to Josh, she realized her spirit couldn’t reconcile her lies being told in the place where she’d let Devlin finger her until she came all over his hand. The only thing that made her heart believe she could do this was out in the sun, out in public, out at a place where they used to come when they first moved to Ajax after they married.

She said, “I told you I fought with him.”

“Say his name, Kimmy.”

She raised her eyes to Josh’s, surprised by the chagrin in his voice.
“Devlin.”

At the sound of Devlin’s name, her husband’s mouth slimmed to a drawn line. “Tell me what happened.”

“You passed out. Amy and I stayed up, People came and went. Sometimes Devlin sat with us—Amy knows him . . .”

“Okay . . .”

“But later it was just the three of us . . .”

“You, Amy, and Devlin.”

“We talked about politics, and our philosophies don’t align. He wants to break up the teacher’s unions, ragging on the Liberals, and he’s doing it all in, like, this haughty tone . . .”

“You can’t be surprised. Why would you even engage him?”

It was a good point. But she was only circumambulating the truth here, anyway. “I know you’re right.” She let it hang, let Josh take it over.

He was quiet a long moment before saying, “I know, Kimmy . . . sometimes you don’t see an argument coming. The next thing you know, you’re inside it. It sometimes feels good when it’s coming and you’re not so eager to avoid it. But why would you even sit and talk with Devlin Stone?—and what the hell would he say that could make you so mad you wanted to hit him?”

She drew it out, prepared herself, said: “He said woman are identified by their ability to have children.” She looked away. This was true.

Josh shifted uncomfortably, took a sip of his beer, wiped his mouth. His brow shrunk, perplexed. ”Was it a trans people argument?”

She nodded. “But what he said, it included me. He’s so callous, so arrogant. And, like, now he was defining me with this . . . disregard. Am I not a woman . . .?”

Josh nodded. He could see it now. He looked away. “I’m sorry, Kimmy.”

“I know.”

He leaned forward and touched his fingertips against her knees. She looked in his eyes. He said, “You can have children, Kimmy.”

“I know I can. In that moment I felt . . .”

“Vulnerable?”

“Victimized,” she said, tightening her crossed arms.

He bowed his head and kissed her thigh just above her knee and the move brought tears to swell under her eyes. She caressed a hand through his hair. He looked up at her and she cupped his cheek.

Josh smiled, said, “I hope you hit him a good one.”

She chuckled, wiped at an eye. “I didn’t.”

“But you fought with him?” Josh sat up, scooted his chair closer, the metal legs squealing on the brick patio. He held her legs at her knees, looking in her eyes.

“I love you,” she said, meaning it one-thousand percent. A warm cascade swelled in her heart and her love for Josh washed away all the shame she felt for what had happened. This was the man she loved deeply, and if Devlin Stone thought she would spread her legs for him next week he was a fool.

“I love you, too,” he said, and the color of his eyes changed right before her. Gone was the heaviness and the hurt he’d bore. She realized Josh had been anxious about what she was going to tell him, and the not-knowing had weighed on him almost too heavy to support.

“I’m so stupid,” she said.

“No, you’re not. You know you’re not.”

“He pulled me into an argument that didn’t even matter. Who cares what he thinks . . .?”

“No one.”

“I just wanted him to shut up.”

Josh said, “Where was Amy in all this?”

“She wasn’t there.” Her scalp tingled and she rubbed the back of her neck.

“You said it was you and Amy and Devlin.”

“When it got heated, she took off.”

“Why wouldn’t she stay and help a friend?”

Amy shrugged.

“Some friend.”

“She should have stayed,” she admitted. But she didn’t stay. And there was more to the story. And if she wanted to armor herself against future revelations of what some people may claim they witnessed, she needed a truthful seed planted . . .

Clean

There was more to the story and he could see she was close to swerving away from it. He said, “Keep going, Kimmy. I’ll hear anything you want to tell me. Please, tell me . . .”

Kimmy steeled herself, and though they sat closer now, it was like she sought some distance, closing him off again by hugging her arms tighter and pushing her back into the chair. He played with her skinny knees. “Tell me, Kimmy, whatever it is we can get through it.”

That made her sigh, and in one simple change of posture, from stiff to sagging, he knew she would tell him now what happened. As bad as what Devlin had said to her, so close to the time their pregnancy failed, he knew the real barrier between them was more than that. She said, “I tried to, you know, grab him. He took my wrists . . .”

“Did he hurt you?”

She shook her head no. Her eyes went down. “I struggled. We were on the ground . . . he pinned my hands above me.”

“He was on top of you?” His heart pounded. Right out of nowhere, his heartbeat became a thundering train. Rage and arousal stormed all at once. He wanted to hunt Devlin down and beat his fucking good head of hair into his brains. But all his mind’s eye focused on was his wife with her hands over her head, on her back in the lakeside grass, her knees up on either side of Devlin’s large frame. Devlin dominating her, looking in her eyes . . .

“Yeah,” she said, eyes down already, sliding to the side now. “It became something weird, Josh.”

“Weird how?” His pulse was a Taiko beat on his ear drums. His brow lowered to a scowl.

“He . . . kissed me.”

“He what?” His voice had stretched hoarse and tight.

“We didn’t . . . it wasn’t a fight he wanted.”

What was she saying? He rubbed his cheeks, then spoke behind his hands.
“Are you saying he sexually assaulted you?”

“Oh, no, Josh. No. Not like that.”

“Why . . . what do you mean—did you kiss him?”

“No—he didn’t kiss my lips, Josh. He kissed my neck. He was trying to turn our fight into . . .” She didn’t finish.

“Did you . . .?” He didn’t finish either.

She looked him in the eye. Her brow had lowered as well. “No, Josh.”

“You told him to get off?”

“We struggled—or I guess I struggled . . . And then . . . When I said I wanted up, he let me up.”

Now he could see how it had happened. After this escapade with Kimmy in the grass while he slept, Devlin’d barged into his tent to taunt him. All riled up from humping Kimmy, Devlin had thought it hilarious to jab the woman’s husband with the What if. The guy was a top level asshole and manipulator.

“That’s it?”

Kimmy’s chin went up and down, her expression bowed with sorrow.

“I’m glad you told me. Are you glad you told me?”

“Yeah,” she muttered, putting her hands between her closed thighs. “I am. I wish you didn’t go behind my back to ask Amy, but I blame myself. I owed you the truth. I was so glad you didn’t press me on what happened, but I didn’t see how unfair it was.”

“I’m sorry I couldn’t let it go, Kimmy. I tried to leave you alone, but I just couldn’t get it out of my mind.”

“I get it. I hoped you’d trust me . . .”

“Hey, that’s not fair . . .”

“No, sorry, Josh, I don’t mean it like that. I mean—”

“Kimmy . . .” The phrase Devlin told me he fucked you formed on his lips, sputtered, then died there. That Devlin would do that to Kimmy then fuck with her husband the way he did, his old high school foil, reduced him to the total nothing he used to be in grade ten. Both husband and wife chumps under Devlin’s thumb might seem comforting, comrades-in-arms and all, but he’d rather be strong. Rather be someone Kimmy could lean on than another victim, another weak man pressed under by a strong one. “What do I do? Do you want me to confront him? I will. I want to. Do we go to the police? . . .”

“The police? No, Josh, it wasn’t like that. It wasn’t what he wanted it to be, but when I wanted to get away he let me go.”

“What a nice guy.”

Kimmy breathed quiet a moment, hands tucked between her thighs still, stretching her back, looking around.

“I trust you, Kimmy.”

“Okay.”

He reached for her, took a hold of one of her slender wrists and put his fingers between hers. She tossed her head one way then the other, trying to avoid his gaze, but he could see a lightening in her eyes. He leaned toward

her, climbed his hands up her long skinny arm, pulling her near. She came to him, all long limbs unfolding and she sat on his lap. He hugged her waist and she hugged his head, then kissed his cheek. He said, “He held you down and kissed you?”

“Yeah,” she whispered near his ear.

“And he wanted it to be more than a fight?”

“What do you mean?”

“That’s what you said. Devlin wasn’t fighting when he had you on your back on the grass. You said he wanted it to be something else.”

“He did.”

“How do you know?”

She frowned, her eyes going to black dashes, her cheeks dimpling high. “He kissed me. You know what I’m saying, right?”

“That’s all? He just kissed you?”

“Does there have to be more?”

He stared at her collar, not knowing how to phrase his question. “Was he . . .”

“He kissed my neck, we were rolling around . . .”

His mouth went to cotton. He leaned aside to sip the huge glass of beer. “He didn’t touch you anywhere else?”

She wasn’t seeing his line of questioning, only looking across the Dragon’s patio with an expression of disbelief—like she couldn’t fathom why her husband didn’t believe her. But it wasn’t disbelief—it was confirmation he sought. There was something about the details that was zapping at his heart strings.

“He had . . .” She scrunched her nose, looked at the other patrons a second, all of them engaged in their meals. “He had an erection . . .”

Some phantom hand squeezed his stomach and adjacent organs while another one feathered a ghoulish touch on his balls. He writhed in the seat, Kimmy going up on his lap, then back down.

“Jesus,” he groaned.

“Do you believe me now?”

“Kimmy, I believed you.”

“I know how it felt.”

His eyes widened, and his ears flooded with a buzzing sound. His heart surged loud. Kimmy leaned away, an arm hooked around his neck, and she sipped his beer. He realized she didn’t mean she knew how Devlin’s erection felt. “You just knew what he wanted,” he said.

She wiped a line of foam from her top lip. “Yeah. It was obvious.”

His heart kicked in his chest again. “Did you see it . . . Or did you feel it?”

“I just felt it,” she said, without regarding him.

He groaned, shifted with her light weight resting on his thighs. “Felt his erection?”

She shook her head, shaggy hair scratching at her collar. “What?—no . . . I mean I felt what he wanted.” But then she raised her eyebrows, cocked her head; an expression that mimed the word: although . . .

“How did you know he had an erection? That’s all I meant.” Now he couldn’t swallow, desperately wanted a sip of beer, but was paralyzed waiting to hear her answer.

“Both, I guess,” she said.

“You saw it and felt it?”

She muttered an uncomfortable sound, hugged his head—the act hiding her face away so she couldn’t be seen.

“Kimmy, serious, tell me.”

“I saw it. He pressed it into me.”

His mind reeled in the most unexpected way. The image of his wife now on her back in Tiffany’s grass had the added knowledge that giant cop’s flashlight between Devlin’s legs was grinding into her. Shit, but where? Into her leg? Into her stomach? God, did Devlin press it against Kimmy’s cute little vagina? . . .

“Hoo,” he sighed, pushing her back from him. His cock had turned to throbbing steel right now, and Kimmy’s thigh leaned on it. How the hell would he explain that to her? He didn’t even understand it himself.

Kimmy flashed him a troubled gaze, offended in a small way that he’d pushed her away. His eyes screamed at her the question he needed answered: Where did you feel it, Kimmy, God, did he dry hump you with that thing? . . . He showed it to me in the tent right after he was with you. . . . But he said, “Can we get out of here?”

“You don’t want to eat, Josh?” Her voice was high and worried.

“I want to go home, Kimmy,” he said, fumbling cash from his pocket to throw down for the waitress, his hands shaking.



The story she told Josh proved too much for him, and now they were walking together under the Dragon’s archway and headed for the Nissan.

Josh'd thrown down twenty dollars for the two beers, then led the way off the patio and across the brick courtyard. She'd had to hurry to keep up.

It wasn't until they were both seated in the quiet of their car that she spoke again. "I hope you're not mad at me, Josh."

He paused, finger hovering over the Qashqai's start button. He swiveled to face her. "I hope you don't think I'm mad at you."

"Why are we leaving?"

"I want to be alone with you."

Now she was worried Josh wanted her somewhere he could grill her further. Maybe say things he didn't want people to overhear. Take her somewhere private where they wouldn't make a scene . . .

"Josh, I know I should've told you."

"Kimmy, I just want to be alone with you. Just to be with you."

She stared in his eyes, looking for meaning. He was practically trembling. There was an earnest, desperate expression on his face. And then he was closing the distance, leaning over the console between them, slipping an arm to her waist and pulling her close. She went to him, bewildered. His reaction wasn't what she thought. He kissed her, she kissed him in return, doing it honestly, feeling enormous relief swelling up from inside her. His kisses became more passionate, and whatever was driving him got into her too, and she put her hands on him, running hard her fingertips against his arms, and over his back. She gasped for breath around his kiss, then returned, pushing her tongue into his mouth. Josh put his hand on her thigh, then between her legs. She opened them. He massaged fingers into the crotch of her shorts and got her gasping again. She hooked her arm around him tighter, leaned closer. Her hand went between his legs, found his arousal steel bolt upright.

He said, "I just want you alone."

“Well get us there then . . .”

Open Drawers

Inside the apartment door, Kimmy turned to him and he backed her to the hallway table, leaned her against it, the crown of her head knocking askew the photograph her father took of that temple in Taiwan. He kissed her.

She said, “Not here,” as she unbuckled his belt.

His cock throbbed even harder than at the Dragon. All this intense arousal from the awful revelation that part of what Devlin had told him was true. Devlin got Kimmy on her back in the grass, held her hands over her head. She didn’t say exactly, but somewhere had seen his arousal in his pants, and Devlin had pressed it against her. All he could think of was the belly of that thing in Devlin’s pants grinding into the cotton cleft of his wife’s soft pussy. And Kimmy, reluctant, mad at this guy one second before, but now Devlin was staring in her eyes and she was feeling his manhood against that most feminine part of her. . . . Devlin said Josh had asked him to do it—there was no way he did. But for whatever reason, what had once worked through him like a poison, this noxious idea of Devlin fucking Kimmy behind Josh’s back, had become something else. From poison to octane.

Kimmy pushed his pants down, underwear going along with it, his erection sticking up straight and proud, and for some reason the aching knowledge that Kimmy had indeed witnessed Devlin’s impressive size didn’t shrink him tonight. It didn’t turn him flaccid, the opposite happened. She stroked him while he leaned over to take her mouth again. She squirmed her face away, and he kissed her neck—like Devlin had kissed her neck. . . . And now he thought of the scenario Kimmy described amplified. Just like the way he was with her now, but it was Devlin with Kimmy in the grass, Kimmy pushing Devlin’s pants down and stroking that giant thing he had.

She whispered, "Let's go to the bedroom."

"I want you right here, right now."

She said, "I want to get a condom . . ."

He chuckled, for some reason considering it undecipherable dirty talk, like maybe Kimmy had some kind of latex fetish. But then he realized she was serious. He backed up so he could look in her eyes. "A condom?"

"Okay?"

"I thought we were trying again."

"I don't know."

"Kimmy, you were the one the last couple days who—"

"We should've talked about it."

"Yeah, we should have. I let you take the lead."

She tucked her chin down, looked in his eyes. "I should go back to work."

"But, Kimmy . . ."

"We can try again some other time."

He rubbed her sides. "Are you afraid?"

The question bothered her, and all the sexual inflation that had expanded them like dirty circus balloons squeaked and deflated. She sat up straighter, got herself off the table to stand, then leaned against the wall. She didn't look at him. "I just don't know what I want."

"We want a family."

"I know."

“You can go back to work if you want, Kimmy. I just don’t want you to do it for the wrong reasons.”

Looking down at the floor, her lips bunched to a pout like she was chewing her inner cheek, she said, “I think I’m tired of making baskets.”

He chuckled, then came to stand behind her and leaned on the table, bracing his hip against its curved edge. “You don’t have to make baskets, Kimmy. You can do whatever you want.”

“I’ve been away for so long, then I worry what’ll happen if the time gets longer . . .”

He caressed her shoulder, and she put her hand over his. His erection had stopped buzzing, but it was still fully engorged and pointed upright, the tip underneath the hem of her cardigan. He stood with her for a long while, thinking about her desire to return to work. But there was more; a blinking beacon in his mind’s eye right in the room with them. He reached down and behind him, slid open the drawer. He peeked down, saw Devlin’s card was still there, plucked it out, held it between thumb and fingers as he rotated around looking at the back and the front. He said, “The other day I found this in the drawer.”

She looked to see what it was, frowned and had to squint to read it. It was like she wasn’t familiar with it. He said, “Was Devlin here?”

Kimmy’s mouth fell open, and her eyes widened. “No . . .”

“Why’s his card here?”

She braced her back against the wall, took the card from him held it in both hands and read Devlin Stone’s name and title. She said, “He gave it to me.”

“When?”

She frowned, chewed her cheek some more. “At the party.”

“Why?”

“I don’t know, Josh.”

“Tell me . . .”

Her head fell back to rest on the wall, slumped aside till her cheek almost touched her shoulder. Her eyes went up. “I think he wants to offer me a job.”

His knees weakened for a moment and he slid to lean against the wall next to her. His mind scrambled trying to make sense of what she’d just told him. There was an incredible betrayal here. She’d talked to Devlin about their future. Enough Devlin offered her a business card. Kimmy’d decided she wanted to try again to get pregnant, then flip-flopped, now saying she wanted to go back to work. Back to work for Devlin?

Was this before or after he’d humped his huge cock between her legs?

He dug fingertips into his cheeks, stood there dumbfounded. Kimmy side-glanced at him, her expression wary. He shook his head, pulled up his pants and buckled them, then headed down the hall.

Kimmy called after him: “Where are you going?”

He waved her off, ambling down the hall to the bedroom. He went in and closed the door behind him, moved to the bed and sat down.

Up was down, left was right. . . . What the fuck was going on? Was Devlin here in the apartment? Was he not here? Did he fuck Kimmy at Tiffany’s? How truthful was Kimmy on the Dragon patio? Was that all that happened? . . .

The bedroom door opened and Kimmy slipped in quietly. She cozied herself in her cardigan, closing the open flaps, shoulders hunched, looking like she was cold though the bedroom was almost too warm. She crossed to him on her toes, barefoot now. She sat down on the bed next to him. “I’ve been meaning to talk to you about it.”

“We should do a lot more talking. I feel like I’m a punching bag right now.”

“Sorry. I really am. Josh, I’m so much happier that I told you what happened. It was wrong to keep it from you. . . . I know you trust me—I leaned too heavily on that. Can’t you forgive me?”

“You want to work for Devlin Stone?”

“I told him no way. But now I don’t know . . .”

“You can’t work for him, Kimmy.”

“I know.” She hung her head, sullen.

Then he felt guilty for laying that on her. He amended: “We can talk about it.”

“I don’t want to work for him, Josh.”

“As his lawyer or something?”

She nodded, ran her hair back from her face, held it behind her neck. “And I speak Chinese.”

“Import export.”

“I think it’s a lot of money. More than I make at the firm.”

“They’re expecting you back.”

“I know. I know I can’t take it.”

Plus, Kimmy, the whole thing where he pinned you down and dry-humped you . . . ?

They wanted a family. But having two good incomes was nice. They could buy a house. A big house. They could have more than two kids. How much could they save five years working for Devlin Stone? If they squirreled away everything Kimmy made and lived off only his income, they could probably buy a house in the suburbs. Buy it cash. “Fuck,” he sighed into his hands.

“This isn’t a real thing, Josh. I didn’t consider it, not really.”

“You kept his card.”

“I forgot I had it,” she said. Then: “I just threw it out now, anyway.”

“You didn’t have to do that. I don’t need a purity test.”

“I don’t want to work for him, Josh. I don’t even like the guy.”

“No one does.”

“Can we just forget about it?”

“Yeah, sure,” he said.

“You want to watch TV?”

“No.”

She cast a sidelong look. “You brought me home to be alone with me. Do you want to lay down?”

He said, “What happened with you and Amy when you took me to the tent?”

She looked away again, out at the sky as it faded from blue to orange. “I told you, we put you into your sleeping bag.”

“Before that,” he said. “You helped me pee.”

“Yeah, I told you that.”

“Amy didn’t want to talk about it.”

“At coffee today? Good,” she said. “I hope you didn’t ask her about it.”

“Did you take my pants down?”

“No, just your zipper.”

“Why did it take me so long to go? You said it took a long time . . . Forever, you said.”

She ran her hair back again, this time letting it fall. “You had to pee, you . . . you had a . . . an erection.”

He shook his head, disgusted with her. Disgusted with himself. “Were you guys laughing at me?”

“No, Josh, I would never laugh at you, why would you even say that?”

“Sometimes I think Amy hates me.”

“She doesn’t, Josh.”

He ran his head around in a circle like his neck was sore. “Did she see?”

“No . . .”

Her voice was quiet. He faced her. “Are you sure?”

“I’m pretty sure.”

“Kimmy, did she sneak a peek? Were you guys laughing because I had a boner?”

“I don’t know, Josh.”

“Did she take a look?”

“I don’t think she did.”

“But she might have?”

“It didn’t come up.”

He leaned forward to catch her eyes, wanting to see if she was joking, and she wasn't. No pun intended. "Everybody was hard for you that night."

Kimmy made a curious expression, not getting his meaning.

He said, "Devlin, too."

"Oh yeah, right," she said without humor.

"Sorry," he said, "I was trying to be funny."

"It's okay."

Now he shifted, faced her again like he did in the front seats of their car. She smiled, her eyes just narrow lines, light from the sunset filling up those dark orbs and turning them chestnut and sending sparks of gold. He kissed her pouting mouth and she touched his shoulder.

He said, "You want to try this again?"

She said, "Do you want to try again?"

"I do," he said, his expression falling. Mind stuck again on Devlin.

She said, "What's wrong?" brushing the back of her knuckles over his cheekbone.

"I keep thinking of him on top of you . . ."

"Don't do that."

"I can't help it."

"Get a condom," she said.

And here they were back to the start—Kimmy deciding she wasn't sure whether now was the time to have a family or not. Making the decision herself that tonight would not be the night to attempt to conceive. No, his wife had been considering taking a high-paying job working as a lawyer for

Devlin Stone's import-export company. Devlin Stone, a man she hated. Said she hated. But she'd work for him for money. And the man had been on top of her, had been arrogant and insulting, and when she fought back this man had put her on the ground, held her hands over her head and let her know how huge his dick was, rubbing it against her.

He couldn't ask Kimmy where Devlin had pressed it. What would that say about her husband? But he was obsessing over the image of Kimmy's knees up on either side of Devlin's hips, her hands held up above her head, not wanting to be there, but fully realizing the power this man had. The power, the money, offering her a job, his strong hands on her slender wrists holding her easily, pinning her, letting her feel how big a man could be. . . . He kissed her again, hungrily.

Soon he had her back on the bed. She unbuckled his belt again, got his pants down. While they both got straighter on the bed, Kimmy slid her shorts off, wriggled out of her cardigan and top, and he fished out a condom from the nightstand.

"Here," she said, naked now and taking over.

He lay back, no pants on, his dress shirt open, his bare stomach heaving up and down. Kimmy tore open the condom packet, tucked her fingers inside its ring, stretched its mouth and pulled it down over his shaft in one easy stroke, the latex crinkling as it unrolled. Kimmy had seen and felt what Devlin had. If it was a hidden lustful spark within him, he could enjoy it. Because he was hard as stone—not stone, definitely not stone. Steel.

He got over top of her, slid himself inside, pinpointing her facial expression, trying to imagine what it would do if that thing Devlin had showed him was going inside her right now. He took her wrists and guided her hands above her head. His hips rolling against hers, he looked in her eyes the way he imagined Devlin did.

There was fear in Kimmy, intermingled with the lust and passion. She understood what he was doing. Understood he was reliving the awful story his wife had told him how another man had pinned her down. Surely she would think that he was reclaiming her, not reliving that awful erotic jewel

that glimmered in the dark web Devlin tried weaving around him. She couldn't see that in him. No, tonight he was taking his wife back after another man had tried to claim her. That's all it was. But he thought of his penis as Devlin's penis inside Kimmy. Devastating her, stretching her insides beyond what was normal. Every little squeak and sigh Kimmy made was amplified in his head tenfold thinking of her with Devlin. He kissed her bare shoulders, sucked on the hard coiled buds of her nipples. When she closed her eyes, he thought she could be thinking of Devlin too. His stomach curdled at the thought, but his hips pounded into her harder.

"You're mine," he whispered, making sure she understood he wasn't thinking about Devlin with her, making sure she understood that she was his.

"All yours," she sighed, and he slowed down now, the strokes getting easy and slow while he got close and cupped her cheeks and kissed her mouth. She caressed his back and they made love gently until he came inside the condom.

Meanings

Eleven at night she woke in Josh's arms, her back to his chest, the two of them spooned in their bed. It was her stomach growling that roused her. After coming back from the Fox and Dragon they'd kind of fought, and she'd thought they'd skidded their marriage into a slippery patch, but somehow it all ended up okay. They'd skipped dinner to make love three times. If she were to peep over her husband's sleeping body to the floor beside the bed she would see three tied-off condoms. Whatever had been insinuating into Josh's sexuality and diminishing his abilities the last while seemed to be corrected.

She didn't deserve such a warm and caring night of lovemaking after all the lies she told him. Not lies, but half-truths. And, of course, there was the stuff omitted. Black-lined by the government, redacted top-secret stuff. Eyes only, and that was for those deemed to have the right security clearance. Josh did not have the right security clearance. Or was he the enemy? She'd made Josh her adversary by what she did with Devlin at the party. Or what she allowed to happen, rather. Now her husband was an opponent she needed to outwit. It was a strange entanglement because what was at stake was how much she loved her adversary. She wanted his feelings spared, and, most importantly, she wanted what was between them preserved and unmarred.

Oh, you mean you want to get away with what happened?

Pretty much, yes.

Only because she loved Josh deeply; had loved him that way since college. The subterfuge was only necessary because she loved him.

That didn't make it okay. She knew that.

Without disturbing Josh she circled in his clutch to face him, their dry and naked bodies slipping together like silk. Josh slept peacefully.

One thing was true: she'd expected him to trust her, and because she didn't want to face for what she was guilty she leaned on his trust. It was laziness. Carelessness. Not careless in the sense that it might damage her ability to get away with what happened. No, it was careless with Josh's heart.

She thumbed his lip, smiling watching the man she'd known so long at peace. She hoped what she'd told him settled the unease he felt. It had helped her, too.

Now she was a woman with a secret, but one whose marriage was righted on its tracks again, the steam engine that drove it beginning to chug. It would be an awful sliver in her psyche but she would burden it, and from here on, what they had would be cherished and preserved. It would take time. Even while making love with Josh her thoughts had drifted to Devlin. It was awful, but Josh had inspired it. Unwittingly, of course, but the act of holding her hands above her head and putting himself inside her while looking in her eyes brought back intense memories.

Before they were interrupted on Tiffany's grass, Devlin had got his cock inside her. Not quite, but almost. Her tightness fought his huge size. It was cheating. Kind of.

It wasn't her will. But she didn't resist it. Then Devlin came to the home she shared with this loving man whose cheek she cupped, and she let Devlin put his fingers inside her. Her heart began to race even thinking about it now. The shame, the awfulness. Devlin Stone was a fucking asshole. When this man she hated shoved his big hand in her panties she'd done nothing. Allowed him to finger her.

Fuck, the way he'd made her come had left her devastated. That was her sliver; that was her burden. The thing with Devlin ended tonight.

Her thumb traced Josh's delicate jaw. She kissed the tip of his nose, then backed herself out of the bed. Shorts and a sweatshirt were donned in the dark and she slipped out of the bedroom, phone in the sweatshirt's pouch, and she padded down the hall to the kitchen.

Devlin was done. That was for certain. But the item Josh had presented her in the hall had stirred from her a strange response. One that had hidden in the bushes of her mind, waiting to jump out and punch her when she walked by unsuspecting.

She stopped under the kitchen's arch and looked at her phone. 11:13. Not too late. She texted.

Kimmy: why'd you leave that business card asshole?

Phone tucked back in the pouch, she brought down a plate, opened the fridge and grabbed baby carrots and some sour cream, cream cheese, and orange juice. From the cupboard she took melba toast. She sat at the island on the kitchen side in the dark and picked at the food, spreading cheese on toast, dipping carrots in sour cream, taking very small sips on her OJ.

Devlin Stone was a manipulative bastard. He'd backed her into a corner somehow, here in her own home, had her submitting to him even though she hated him, then he fingers her—another man's wife—makes her come all over the place. Embarrass herself with a wet sexual deluge between her legs. Leaves her there, legs shaking. But that sneaky prick left a funny little time bomb he must have chuckled about later: His damn business card.

When Josh had presented it to her, she had nothing prepared to say. It had slapped her across the cheek. She spoke absently, seeking a measure of truth to plaster into the crack forming in her story.

I was thinking of going back to work.

Kind of true. But work for Devlin? No way. Yet . . .

Her phone buzzed against her stomach; she put it on the counter and lit it up.

Devlin: wanted to make sure you had my number

Fucking asshole. That was a mean and terrible thing to do to her. There was no reason to do that other than to mess with her.

Kimmy: I have your number

Devlin left the card because he didn't care about her marriage. A fling with her was just a big joke to him.

Devlin: what's the big deal?

Kimmy: Josh found it

She cursed him, shaking her head, watching for his response to arrive while she packed the lids back on the dairy tubs. Nothing came, and now she cursed herself for ever engaging with Devlin Stone. What would make her want a guy like that in her life? Such a toxic presence, one she'd happily severed from her life after high school. All that shit he'd spun to her in the hallway, how she'd matured the best out of the girls from Dalton, was

sleazy privileged white boy talk she saw through before the spinning gold even wove from between his lips.

The phone dinged on the island counter, and she returned.

Devlin: I wanted you to think about what I said

She folded her arms, thinking how what he'd said was exactly what a woman like her did want to hear. She was better than those skanks. Once they were all out of high school she always knew it would be apparent.

Kimmy: said about what?

Devlin: it's my business card . . .

Non-sequiturs, incomplete answers. Like he was testing her. Business card. Business. Okay, he was talking about the job. He'd never even made a formal offer, just a bunch of what-ifs and ragging on her basket business.

Kimmy: if that's how you run your business what do you think my answer is?

Leaving a card in her hall table was juvenile.

Devlin: what was my question?

Now she chuckled, a feeling of satisfaction easing her shoulders.

Kimmy: good night Devlin now stay out of my life

She stood by the counter waiting to see what his response would be. No return came.

The counter was cleaned, plate and cutlery loaded into the dishwasher, then she wiped up with a damp cloth. Still no reply. Good.

Phone in her pouch, she padded back to the bedroom and then the bathroom, brushed her teeth, washed her face, then went to the bed quietly, trying not to disturb Josh.

At the bedside her phone buzzed against her stomach again. She opened it.

Devlin: see you next Tuesday

Such a fucking asshole. She set her jaw firm, growled a soft sound in her throat and mimed the act of throwing her phone to the floor to smash it to pieces. She set it on the nightstand safely, slipped out of her clothes and crawled back into bed with Josh. She rolled her back to him, shimmied rearward into the warm bed-space against his body. He stirred, and she found his arm and closed it around her.



Now the sex was done, the wild and stormy seas calmed, Josh was left in the placid water aftermath of the lust that had overtaken him at the Dragon. He lay in the dark, holding Kimmy against him and contemplating the business card.

Something had registered in his mind, but in the heat of the moment it had gone unchecked. He examined it now: Kimmy acted at first as though she'd never seen the card before.

What did that mean?

It made sense that Kimmy didn't know. Devlin had put it there for Josh, wasn't that right? He'd put it there to fuck with Josh later at his whim. Was that the case? But then wouldn't that mean Devlin had indeed been in the apartment?

Or was he missing something?

He'd at first thought Devlin was trolling Facebook for photos of their apartment so he could sound familiar with it. That had made a lot of sense. Because Kimmy had not cheated on him; it was impossible. But now he had to consider Devlin had been here. Devlin or a third party. Did Devlin have mutual friends with them?

Shit: Amy.

Amy'd had an on-again off-again love-hate thing with Devlin for long stretches all throughout high school. But would Amy hide a business card for Devlin or help him in any way? She didn't stay in touch with Devlin since going abroad for university, or uni as she called it, at least it didn't seem that way at the reunion. A lot of dry unimpressed glances between them, but playful-like, as though there may be something swimming just under the surface. So now he tried to recall the days up to the party. Who

had come through the house? He was almost positive Amy hadn't been here at all, even when he wasn't here. Karina was for sure. But Karina would never help Devlin in a million years.

Thoughts of accomplices was a lost cause. It wasn't likely to be that elaborate a setup. He'd have to consider now Kimmy lied to him about Devlin being here. But she didn't have sex with him. No, that wasn't on the table. So what, then? Why would Kimmy lie?

The job thing.

Devlin had excited her with the prospect of going back to work, then ramped it up by offering her a high-paying job. Kimmy's salary was satisfactory where she worked. It was the low end of what you might expect a lawyer of her age and talent, but she went into law to help people, and was compensated for her work in immigration in ways other than money. Did she feel guilty for being interested in money, for being interested in lawyering for the cash? That would be like her. Devlin comes by to apologize. He offers her a job. She says no but thinks about it. Later finds out Devlin slipped his card in the drawer, Devlin one step ahead of everybody. Keeping Kimmy's mouth shut by making her feel guilty, and all so he could fuck with Josh Waters. But fucking why? What a waste of time.

Devlin fucking with him at the party made sense just because of proximity and situation, but continuing to fuck with him in the week after and going to all this effort . . .? How much fun was it to fuck with Josh Waters at the age of twenty-eight . . .? Is this successful and busy guy really playing juvenile games? . . .

What if Josh Waters wasn't even the subject of his attention?

Shit, what if Devlin just got the hots for Kimmy and the real game he was running was on Kimmy, and this nonsense he was doing with Josh was the added bonus or perhaps some trick or subterfuge, some way of keeping Josh away from the truth about Kimmy? What if Josh wasn't even the intended target?

That made his scalp tingle at the sheer insidiousness. His heart pounded harder and he snaked arms tighter around Kimmy, kissing the point of her bare shoulder.

If this was about Kimmy, he needed to act. Confront Kimmy, confront Devlin, do something . . .

A small measure of personal pride was keeping his door from fully opening. Devlin had come into the tent and showed Josh his dick, said he'd fucked Kimmy, taunted him saying Josh'd asked him to do it. . . . The idea of telling Kimmy that turned his stomach, and, worse, for some reason it made him seem weak, and he hated for Kimmy to see him that way now he was grown. It was the power of the bully. All the things that had been done to him growing up had been kept to himself, too ashamed to ask for help.

Talk about poison: if Kimmy heard that Devlin said Josh asked him to fuck her she wouldn't believe it. But it would be inside her system, coursing through her architectures of knowledge and understanding, and there would be pulses of occasional doubt, lying in bed with him here at night and wondering . . . What if Josh really did ask Devlin to fuck her?

Fuck this.

He pulled back the sheet, his mind wrung out and stressed. Kimmy was naked next to him. In the gray dawn light he admired his wife's lean body, curved like the little spoon, her skin pure and satiny, her hair a tangled nest around her sleeping profile, long hands gently cupped by her cheek. She breathed softly. The sheets were pushed down further, resting at the gentle knob of her knee bone. He caressed her thigh. She didn't stir. He gently pressed a thumb into the squashy hump of her ass cheek, watched as it sunk into her flesh. Her sex was exposed to him the way her legs were bent. The soft curves of her mound run with a narrow labia lip squiggle, a sparse thatch of her pubic hair allowing the dirty details of his wife's sexual opening to be seen. He took a lusty chance and brushed the backs of his fingers against the protective layer of her fur, felt her heat there, his stomach pulling tight at the thought of their wonderful night together making love.

There had been something dark at work since the party. It was him who had to shoulder some blame, too. Getting wasted the way he did was irresponsible and disrespectful to Kimmy. It allowed an event to occur that wouldn't have happened if he'd abstained from too much drink, enjoyed his wife's company, and made sure she got to bed safe and sound at his side. The thing that had happened was terrible. Kimmy was a tough cookie and she could recover from an incident like that, but what Devlin did wasn't right. Devlin Stone had tried to fuck her, of that he was sure. No wonder he slunk into Josh's tent to gloat. Kimmy had rebuffed Devlin in an awkward moment he probably wasn't used to.

The future was going to contain less Devlin Stone and more Kimmy Chang.

He covered her up, kissed her hip, then her shoulder again. When she was under the bedding, he kissed her cheek. Now she stirred. He patted her hand and she tried to squeeze his fingers but he was getting up, wanting her to stay sleeping. He stood watching to make sure she was out again, then got dressed as quiet as he could.

The only thought he would allow of Devlin Stone moving forward was the image of the man between Kimmy's legs, trying to kiss her, Kimmy pinned down, Devlin's huge cock rubbing into her leg. That was an unexpected gift from Devlin Stone, probably one the bully would regret giving to him. It frightened him, sure, but it also super-charged him. Put anger in his heart, roused pride, pushed the feeling of being challenged. It put lust in him too, a weird arousal. But that arousal drove home the intense feelings of love he had for his wife. It was the gift of resolve to own his woman. Even now, in the dim morning light he could feel a growing arousal between his legs at the mere caressing of the thought Kimmy felt another man's erection pressing into her. It made his heart pound with love for her.

The sex they had last night was pure love and care. He'd performed admirably, thank god. He was good to her, he made her happy. They'd shared. It'd been tender. Wonderful.

At the Dragon, they'd worked out the truth; Kimmy had been straightforward and honest with him. He was inspired. They'd skipped

dinner so they could stay in bed and touch each other all over. He'd come three times.

Maybe that was the end of whatever badness had occurred at the party. He believed it.

Let it die.

That was the decision. Let it die, move forward.

Watch Kimmy, care for their relationship, look for trouble, leave the players alone, play the game, nurture what he had with Kimmy, support her in whatever she may be going through as she struggled to find meaning in her future; babies or work. But let it die, Josh, old boy. Don't pump life into something bad and rotten, just be the man Kimmy needs you to be, not some whining complainer who doesn't trust her, who cries about how mean the other boys are being to him. It was man-up time.

He snapped the waistband of his underwear, eyeing Kimmy still, made his way to the kitchen, pulling out his phone so he could block the number Devlin'd texted him from.

Behind him in the bed he'd left his wife sleeping off a wonderful night of sex; naked, satisfied, sleeping. He was going to be her man. But first he needed a big breakfast because he was fucking starving.

II

Thursday, July 16

Stretching The Truth

On Thursday she drove Josh to work so she could have the car to go shopping in the afternoon after yoga at the gym. At lunch she had a scheduled gym date with Karina. It was a long-standing Thursday yoga class, a once a week get-together they usually followed with a vegan meal at a café on Harwood, south of the 401. But since the party at Tiffany's, she hadn't heard from Karina. She passed it off, trying not to fret, knowing that the coming week for Karina would be a busy one; Karina had a work deadline and a lunch with the parents of the new guy she'd been dating since January and she'd worried about it. Karina'd almost skipped the reunion and the party at Tiffany's altogether, but since going to Tiffany's had been all Karina's idea, once Josh and she had agreed to it, Karina knew it would be bad manners to be the one to back out.

Karina witnessed what happened at Tiffany's. Caught her and Devlin in the grass, then hounded them later when they were in the bathroom.

Things that morning at Tiffany's had been worked out; not fixed but smoothed over. There'd been arguments amongst them, Karina, Amy, and two other girls from high school who'd been privy to the scandal; the girls wanted to blame Devlin, and she was stuck defending him. After their postulations were presented, she was swayed. She blamed Devlin too, and had the others support. Josh shows up in the kitchen, everyone helps her put a lid on that roiling pot, and leaving Tiffany's altogether should have been the act of turning off the burner. The high school reunion was over, and when she got the reminder next time for their fifteen- or twenty-year, it would go straight in the trash, and she wouldn't see the majority of those people ever, ever again. No more Devlin, for sure.

She'd thought.

It hadn't quite turned out that way, though. Somehow Devlin was still in her life. Somehow she'd managed to make matters worse.

None of the other girls who knew, or at least had been apprised of what happened, were in touch with her, nor were they friends in her normal life. She had two voices coming from her shoulders; the proverbial angel and devil. Amy was the devil, telling her to go for it, get some, all the disparaging things she'd said about Josh, then seeing his penis, teasing, tattling to Devlin about it. Amy loved that Kimmy'd met Devlin in the apartment days after Tiffany's party. Whatever it was about Amy, if you had something to confess she did this thing that had you admitting all your sins, welcoming it, more than absolving, she was encouraging . . .

The angel on her shoulder was Karina, but Karina wasn't talking to her.

When Karina didn't show for the yoga class, it sunk her heart. Made her feel anew all the guilt for what she'd done. And Karina didn't know what had happened since the party . . .

Ten minutes into the class though, sweat trickling her back already, the door opens and Karina's hustling with her mat slung over a shoulder, tip-toeing to the back of the class.

She'd waved and, thank god, Karina'd come to her, lay her mat in the spot Kimmy'd reserved. They exchanged smiles, but she'd be a fool not to notice a stiffness in her friend. They finished the class together, the whole time her stomach getting knotted tighter.

Both of them still in tights, they sat facing each other on the wooden benches in the gym's changing rooms, women moving around them, disrobing and heading to the showers. Kimmy waited for the coast to clear, knowing Karina was upset, wanting to hear what her friend thought.

"I think I'm still mad at you," Karina said, unable to look in her eyes, hands clasped between her knees.

“I deserve it,” she said, looking past her shoulder to make sure they wouldn’t be overheard. “I can’t believe you didn’t talk to me all week.”

“I really am mad, Kimmy. . . . And you didn’t call me either.”

“I was afraid. Afraid you’d still be mad at me.”

Karina whispered, “How could you do that . . .?”

“You don’t have to tell me . . .”

“At one point I had my phone in my hand and I was going to call . . .”

Kimmy’s shoulders slumped, her face sullen, looking down. She pulled her hair back, held it to one side of her neck.

“Not to talk to you . . .”

Now she looked up, saw Karina’s eyes were reddened. She whispered, “To talk to who?”

“Josh,” Karina said.

“Don’t do that—why would you do that to me?”

“To you? You know what it’s done to me? How do you think my week has been?”

“I’m sorry . . .”

“I can’t sleep, I can’t think about anything else . . . it’s like this heavy lump in my stomach,” she said, holding a fist above her navel. “Every time I get quiet, the thought of it just jumps out at me and gets me all . . . twisted.”

“Would you really have told Josh?”

“No,” she said. “It’s on my back, you know?—wanting to do the right thing.”

“That’s the right thing?”

Karina looked at her pleadingly. “Isn’t it?”

A straggler from the yoga class came in the change room, went to her locker a half dozen down from theirs so they stopped talking till she’d headed to the shower.

Karina said, “I’d rather not know at all. It’s the burden that’s so hard, knowing a secret, knowing how you’d break Josh’s heart. Devlin Stone? I mean, come on.”

“You don’t have to worry.”

“Why?”

“He knows. Josh knows.”

“He knows?” Her voice was a fearful high-pitch.

“I told him,” she said.

Karina couldn’t believe it, nodding forward. “You did?”

“He’s not stupid. I’m a terrible liar. It’s a bad mix.”

“What happened?”

“The way home from the party I told him it was just an argument, me and Devlin, and I didn’t want to talk about it. Josh lets me off the hook, but he’s stewing. I did nothing to make him feel any better about it. For days. . . . It leads to a blow out. You know, I actually felt worse about the lying than what happened. The lying is so direct and personal, and I do it looking in his eyes.”

“A blow out? Is he okay?—are you guys okay?”

“You wouldn’t believe it.”

A woman emerged from the shower, passing through in her slapping slides. They both slipped out of their tights, wrapped themselves in towels, grabbed their shower kits. The coast was clear again and Kimmy tossed her kit to the bench, got close to Karina.

“I took him out for a beer the other night. Somewhere public so he wouldn’t lose his shit on me. I told him what happened.”

“You really did?”

She nodded. Karina touched her arm, being supportive. “So I told him what happened.” She shrugged. “He blamed Devlin.”

“It was Devlin.”

“I know.”

“Was he hurt?”

She shook her head, avoiding Karina’s eyes as she skated around the truth. “He . . .” She looked up at the metal rafters. This part was true. True and astounding. “We . . . couldn’t be better right now.”

“Really?” Karina’s voice trailed up—not disbelief, but a hopeful rising.

“I mean it. We went home from the bar, and we . . . we were with each other all night. Touching, kissing. It was amazing.” A real tear spilled over her lid and she wiped.

“Why didn’t you call me to tell me that?”

“It was just the other night. Tuesday. I knew I’d see you here today. When you didn’t show up on time my heart sunk so low.”

“Come here,” Karina said, smiling. She embraced Kimmy, and Kimmy put her arms around her back. “I’m sorry, Kimmy, I never knew I was such a shitty friend.”

They were in towels and otherwise bare, so they kept it brief, stepping back, adjusting their terry wraps. She said, “It reset us or something. Not what happened at the party reset us, but being honest. Like, I totally forgot how amazing Josh was or, I don’t know . . . not forgot, but . . . took for granted.”

“He loves you so much, Kimmy. Always has.”

“I told him, Karina, told him the truth. And it made us better.”

“You’re so lucky,” Karina said soft and soothingly.

“Are you okay now?”

“I’m okay. That’s the best thing I could hear. I mean it. And I’m sorry I let you down.”

“I let you down. I let myself down. Josh and I . . . we’re going to be okay.”

They showered together, dressed, then Kimmy took Karina to lunch, the weight lifted. Karina was light, relieved, and the thought that Karina could have told Josh what happened—tattled on her—got her squirming while she showed a smile all through their Buddha bowls and green tea smoothies. But it was done, the truth told for the most part, and also crystallized before her via her own words was a new happy love for her husband. She’d danced around just how much she’d actually confessed to Josh, but the real gold nugget in what she’d said to Karina was how even a facet revealed to her sweet Josh had revived them and reminded her how much she shared with the man she’d been with since high school. She didn’t deserve him . . .

Never would have occurred to her to buy lingerie, but here she was filing through the racks at La Vie en Rose. It was an unexpected activity, after lunch with Karina coming out to the RioCan Durham Center to hit the Costco and the Michaels and the Wal-Mart, walking from the Nissan to the Costco, looking up and seeing the high end classy storefront face for the women’s undergarment boutique. She’d thought of Josh. Thought of their sweet time in bed together the other night. Like old times. In college, homework and class the heaviest burden, the sex then had been carefree.

They definitely weren't trying to get pregnant. But even then had they ever been playful? Josh at times would get lusty and they would fool around a little but why had she never tried to dress sexy for him? It's not like she had terrible underwear, but she'd never presented herself to him like a well-wrapped package his hands would shake while opening and revealing. The idea tickled her.

So now she had some choices to make.

At first she'd liked the bright green. Bright green bra and panties. Sexy cuts. But green? Then she found the garter belts and hose and laughed that off, thinking no way. But then went back. Now she had an embroidered black garter belt with stocking straps, black hose with a stitch line up the back. The bright green was off the table. She'd toyed with the red and with a lavender but held them up to her skin, and while the red looked striking, nothing beat basic black with her hair. When she wore black, she knew it made her look dark and mysterious and unreadable. Not to be crossed. And what better way to present herself to her husband than in an intimidating way? If she strutted out of their bathroom in the bright green bra and panties he could laugh or giggle and she mightn't have the resolve to not feel foolish. In black she knew Josh's expression would be wowed. Wowed and frightened. That made her smile, thinking of him on the bed and she comes out in this . . .

A better revelation was needed, better than just opening the bathroom door, and the boutique had a whole room labeled 'kimonos.'

A black kimono. All black, three quarter sleeves, a big rose and leaves scrawled at the hip. Come out of the bathroom like that, Josh seeing it, liking the robe, then she opens it. . . . Black pushup bra (with a little padding to make it look like she had something), black panties over a garter belt, straps to the stockings; kimono comes off, turn, shows him the back, the high swoop of the cheeky cut briefs with their deep dark green ruffles you had to be close enough to see.

Even her own heart raced at the thought. Hand to her collar she could sense the flitting pulse in her neck and wrist.

At the checkout, the attendant who'd helped her said, "Your husband is going to freak."

In a smoky mirror behind the cash she saw the happy dazed smile on her own face, the gleam in her eyes.

She said, "And I just came for groceries."

Another dilemma.

The groceries were emptied from the cloth bags, canned goods in the cupboards, dairy in the fridge, produce on the counter where she leaned, looking at the plastic bag that held their re-stocked toiletries. On a fun lark she'd made a strange purchase she was now weirded out to address. It'd been done on the tail end of the high buying the lingerie brought, the lingerie's high coming from a relief of the tension between her and Karina, and the surge of love she'd felt for Josh after realizing how things had changed since . . . Devlin.

But now she was home and the happy wave crest she'd been surfing was fading, dumping like adrenalin after the rush.

In the Wal-Mart bag with the toothpaste and anti-perspirant and Josh's shave cream . . . was a paper pharmacy bag. Inside the pharmacy bag was the renewal for her Ortho Tri-Cyclen, her contraceptive pills. Unprotected sex would have to wait six weeks so she'd also bought a twenty-four count of Trojan Double Ecstasy condoms.

Now she put her hand in the bag, plastic rustling, found the small cardboard lozenge, light as air, heavy with tenor. Withdrew it. Black, gold letters. A three-pack of Trojan Magnum condoms.

When she'd plucked them from the peg, it'd been done with a funny hair toss and complementary chuckle. Grabbed the normal size condoms, saw the Magnums, laughed, plucked, kept walking; all upbeat and cheery. The rationale? Who knows. It was like she'd said to herself in the moment Hey, better safe than sorry. But funny, like she didn't mean it. But she bought

them. Even flinched when they got scanned at the checkout like the guy would be thinking This lady's got two boyfriends. But she didn't have two . . .

No. She didn't buy them for another boyfriend. It was funny. Maybe curiosity.

With the produce sorted, she put away what went in the fridge, fruit in one drawer, veggies in the other, melon on the counter, bananas on their hanger, the remainder laid out to be washed for the garden salad she would make. It was her soapy hands rubbing the cucumber that brought the slithering, heavy feeling between her legs.

She set the cucumber aside, shook water from her hands then dried them. The two boxes of condoms were aligned on the counter. Then from each she withdrew a foil square packet. The one she'd bought for Josh was opened, the rubber retracted. She eyed the circumference. The Magnum's packet torn, she removed the larger condom and lay them on their packets and lined them up. Not much difference to the eye.

A greenish banana—a good sized one—was pulled from the bunch on their counter hanger, and its butt end pushed into the hoop of Josh's condom, then she rolled it down just past halfway. The latex clung to the banana. This dirty act had her stomach rolling and a weird smile tugged to one side. Now she tried re-rolling the condom, shaking it off the banana before trying the same task with the larger condom. It slid with ease, hung baggily. If she really whipped it, she imagined she could fling the Magnum off the banana without peeling with her fingers. Also noticeable was where it was largest. The end. A man would have to have a large and voluminous cock head to fill out the Magnum. She picked at it playfully.

With a few tugs on the tip she was able to pull the Magnum off the banana. Now she raised the cucumber. A long, thick dark green phallus of enormous size; maybe eight or nine inches long, and thick enough she couldn't close her grip tight on it. She pushed the fat butt end of the cucumber into the Magnum and had to squeeze and snap the condom to get it halfway down its length. The cucumber filled out the Magnum. She handled it, running her fingers, gripping, lightly stroking. It was only four o'clock.

All the condom wrappers and boxes were returned to the plastic bag and she brought it to the bedroom, tossing it on the en suite bathroom counter. She still held the condom-covered cucumber. Her stomach still knotted.

She lay on their bed, head on a pillow, legs parted and stared at the inactive ceiling fan. Eyes open, she stopped seeing, instead her mind picturing the night sky, a trail of fire smoke. Her arms were overhead and she didn't even struggle.

Now she lay the cucumber on the front of her thigh, and even though it had been washed in hot water it still chilled her. She rolled it, let it grow warmer. Rolled it more, let it fall between her thighs. She nosed it up inside the leg of her shorts, felt it begin to prod at the crotch of her underwear. Stomach pulled in, she ran her free hand underneath the front of her button up shorts, hooked a finger under the leg of her panties. The cucumber prodded again, now pushing against the outer edge of her vulva. She shimmied, guided the cucumber until that large end mashed against her labia.

Her hips humped a slow rhythm on their own. The cucumber pressed in time, seeking to get inside her. The cucumber was too large and something about that was so exciting. She pushed with her hand, flexed her ass to raise her hips to meet the intrusion. She was too tight. Her opening was too small. The cucumber was too big. But, god, did she want it inside her . . .

Cucumber crosswise on her stomach, she unbuttoned her shorts, pushed them down with her panties, got them right off. She stroked the cucumber's reservoir tip along the groove of her hot wet furrow, narrowing in on her aperture, finding it, then using both hands to guide the cucumber inside herself. It hurt but it didn't stop her. She grimaced and bit her lip. It didn't go in easily. Devlin wasn't wearing a condom at Tiffany's. The air had been cold, the skin of his cock against the inside of her thigh curling iron hot. She lay there helpless—no, acting helpless—letting Devlin Stone try to shoe horn that enormous cock into her vagina . . .

Now her breaths came quicker, her hips humping faster. She held the cucumber with only one hand, not needing it deeper, only needing it to feel persistent. The fingers of her other hand thrummed over her clit. The

knotted pearl in her oyster was ripe and bursting, and the pleasure got her moaning all alone on a weekday masturbating in bed. She came. She kept going. Got the cucumber a little deeper but stopped. She thought of her ass on the cold bathroom counter, looking between her legs and seeing Devlin's throbbing and veiny monster poking against her fur. She came again, this time harder.

But this time the sexual sweat flooded her with coppery twanging guilt.

She sat up, moved aside, disgusted to see the wet she'd stained on the bed cover. The Magnum was unrolled, crumpled, taken to the bathroom where she cut it up with scissors and flushed the pieces away. The quilt was swapped for a clean one. In the kitchen the cucumber was sliced out of phallic existence and reduced to dinner for her and Josh.

The sickness she felt now ruined the surprise of her lingerie, and she hid it boxed away in the closet, hoping she would soon have the same excitement return that had got her trying it on in the first place . . .

III

Tuesday, July 21

Possibilities

Tuesday morning they woke up in bed together, his arm around Kimmy, both of them facing the dawning blue sky beyond their apartment window. He hummed a gentle leonine sound, more for himself, an honest grumble of appreciation for the woman in his arms. Kimmy's light hand moved to stroke at his wrist.

"Oh, you're up?"

"Yeah," she whispered, still stroking.

They'd made love again last night. That was every night in a row since last mid-week. Not marathon displays like that first night, usually only once, and last night had been half an hour of love and caring. They were both still naked.

Something had changed since the party at Tiffany's. It was like he'd been shoved into a ring of bloodthirsty people to face an opponent in a fist fight. The opponent larger, intimidating, no way for him to vanquish this foe, one look and anyone would know it. He and the opponent danced around, and he'd taken body blows, but, without warning, it had ended. Someone'd called the fight. No towel was thrown, the crowd merely dispersing, the opponent moving on to find someone else to pummel into the ground. No more texts came. The fear had subsided. Kimmy hadn't brought up going back to work, and he wouldn't bring it up either. She'd go back to the immigration firm. Her job was waiting for her, just a phone call away. Bringing it up, talking about it, could circle them back to the beginning of this awful serpentine maze: talking about Devlin.

Could she work for him? How could she? The guy'd pinned her down, tried to . . . What? Sexually assault her? Rape her? No . . . But he'd made his intentions known. Then, surreptitiously to the woman's husband, he'd showed just exactly the cards he held in his hand.

Now all he and Kimmy were left with was that awful adrenaline spike, that shockwave graph of last week. But in its wake, something else had been delivered besides the pain. An odd, and yes, perverted pleasure. His performance had been spot on every night. Like clockwork. Draw the pistol, aim, shoot. Fires every time. And the secret? While he held his wife lovingly, making love in their bed, all he had to do was hearken back to that evening on the Dragon's patio, Kimmy recounting how Devlin held her down, tried to kiss her, the two of them in the grass. And if he wanted a real turbo boost, he'd just picture the humped bulge of Devlin's pronounced erection pushing into Kimmy's leg. Into her stomach . . . Into the cleft of her vulva . . .

"Are you kidding me?"

"What," he laughed, "sorry," kissing behind her ear. He'd grown to full hardness, and she was aware. Their naked bodies clasped front to back, his erection had grown into the softness of her bent rump.

"You're an animal," she said.

"I'll let you off the hook this morning as I have to get in the shower."

"Don't feel like a quickie?"

"Let's leave it for tonight," he said.

She was silent a long while, and he cocked his head to look at her profile on the pillow. She answered finally. "Deal."

He poked his cock in between her ass cheeks, said, "That's what happens when I wake up and you've got nothing on."

She squirmed her butt against him, purposely flipping the crack in her butt cheeks against his boner, making it flick. He ran his hand on her ribs.

She said, "Is it okay if I drive you in to work today?"

"You want to have the car?"

"Yeah. That okay?"

"You and Karina got a gym date?"

"No, I just feel like going out today."

"No problem," he said, kissing her shoulder. "You going to sleep in?"

"No, I'll get up. You want breakfast?"

"Sure," he said, slipping backwards out of the bed, walking to the bathroom with his upright erection bouncing up and down and side to side.

Out of the shower now and dressed for work, he paused in the hall, knotting his tie and looking in Kimmy's basket room. On her web store, she'd put up the notice: Orders on pause while Katt catches up!

She said she was going to close it, but had to do some thinking. She paused it for now while she finished the orders that had already come in. That meant sometime in his near future they'd have to talk about her going back to work. That would be fine, but not for Devlin. The farther Devlin appeared in the rearview mirror the better.

They ate breakfast together, then while he scrubbed the dishes with his tie flicked over his shoulder, Kimmy darted back to the bedroom to slip in to some sweats. She drove him into Swanson, and they smooched over the console, her body warm under his hand.

He texted her mid-morning to ask her how it was going. It took a while but she responded she was enjoying a day off. Said she might catch a movie later. That gave him a happy feeling, thinking of her taking some much

needed Kimmy-time. Putting her thoughts in perspective. Making the right choice . . .

At lunch, he invited Steve over after work for some beers and some pizza, probably a lot of Xbox. In trade, Steve would drive him home. Then he called his cousin, Meyer, see if he'd like to join. He would, and he had his daughter (who Josh and Kimmy called niece) for the week and Josh said little Sophie was more than welcome Meyer was. Texted Kimmy then to let her know. Saying, Don't do dinner tonight, pizza's on Papa—Steve and Meyer coming over, bringing Sophie. She didn't respond. He wondered what movie she'd gone to. Two hours later she texted back a thumbs-up and applauding hands, Kimmy always happy to see Sophie.

After work, he arrived home at the apartment with his entourage. Through the front door holding six-year-old Sophie on a hip, one of her soft arms hooked around the back of her uncle Josh's neck. Meyer carried the three pizza boxes. A Vegetarian, Meat Lover's (for balance), and a Hawaiian because Sophie loved pineapple.

Completely by chance, Meyer had also married an Asian woman. A Korean beauty named Hyun he met at engineering school. But things had not fared well, and Meyer and Hyun separated two years ago, divorced a year ago. Custody was split equally. Hyun had not remarried, and secretly, after drinks, Meyer would often surmise about her sexual identity. "Always talking about her friends's bodies, Josh, I'm telling you . . . No, I'm serious, even Kimmy, always talking about Kimmy . . . Saying what?—You know, you've seen her, God, you sleep in the same bed with her," Meyer'd said, "When Kimmy got that haircut, I came to pick up Sophie that weekend, Hyun had the same one. The same haircut. Tell me that's not weird . . ."

Steve brought up the rear with two bags from the Jug City with 2L bottles of pop and bags of Doritos. It would be two hours of Just Dance for Sophie's sake (God help them), then when Sophie crashed, there were a dozen members of an Al-Qatala terror cell he knew they would combine forces to battle.

The apartment was dark. No sign of Kimmy. He flicked on the lights, moved into the kitchen, nudged his chin to show Meyer where to set the boxes down. Steve came in as well, putting bottles in the fridge saying “Where’s Kimmy?”

“Don’t know,” he said, “car’s out front. She’s home.” Leaned over the pass-through counter, he shouted, “Kimmy?”

No answer. “I don’t know,” he said, “is it her gym night?”

Steve said, “She’s not gonna play video games?”

He said, “She’ll eat, dance with Soph, then I think she’ll hit the gym. You ever know Kimmy to play Modern Warfare?”

The bedroom door opened now, a quiet click down the hall. Kimmy emerged, the light from the kitchen spilling on her. Her hair was messy; she was still wearing the same sweats she’d dropped him off in. Her eyes looked puffy.

He said, “You okay?”

“Yeah,” she said, “why?” unsmiling.

“Did you just have a nap?”

“I did,” she said, embarrassed, Meyer coming around to her side, saying “Give us a hug,” and they embraced.

Sophie brought up the rear, and Kimmy brightened instantly, squatting, rump to heels, putting both arms around Sophie and hugging her tight then grunting as she hoisted her up and holding her on her hip. “Oh my God, Sophie, you’ve got so heavy. Have you been working out?”

Sophie made a muscle; Kimmy kissed it. “What kind of pizza did you get?” Kimmy said, “I hope somebody got Hawaiian . . .”

Sophie said they did, pointing to the box. Steve performed a quick shell game with the pizza boxes, moving them around in confusing patterns,

changing their lineup, stopping then and saying in a barker's voice, "Go ahead, Sophie. Pick one—whatever it is, you gotta eat it . . ."

Kimmy laughed, and some of the weirdness left Josh seeing her come fully alight. Sophie said, "The Hawaiian one," extending a hand with three-pronged fingers pointing at all the boxes.

Kimmy cooed, stroked Sophie's wrist, kissed her hand saying "That's my smart girl, you're such a smart girl," getting Sophie giggling.

Everyone loaded their plates, the guys and Sophie filed into the living room and fired up the Xbox. He lingered to talk to Kimmy. She put vegetarian slices on her plate and he stood behind her. "Feeling alright?"

"Totally fine," she said. "I just woke up."

"You had a nap?"

"I did."

"Did you go out?"

"I did. I was out a lot."

"What did you do?"

"Nothing, poked around. Went to the park—it was so nice today—sat on a bench . . ."

"Thinking?"

"Thinking," she said.

He kissed the back of her neck. "That's good. Did you see a movie?"

"I went to the theater but I couldn't decide what I wanted to see, so I went to the mall and poked around."

"Going to go to the gym tonight?"

She nodded.

“Are you?” He’d hoped she’d stay with them, hang out, soak up some of that Sophie energy. She’d spent the day thinking; it was likely to be whether she’d go back to work or have kids. He was okay with her choice, but now it wriggled through him that wanting Sophie to be here might be because that was his choice. Kids. But, shit, a couple more years work, both of them making a salary, the house they could buy . . .

What if she made more money? What if she worked for Devlin for two years? What if two years was the same as five years at the immigration firm? What if she worked two years for Devlin, sucked it up, took one for the team? Just two years and they could be moving into the suburbs, nice big house, Kimmy with a round tummy . . .

He smiled again, got super close to her, making her flinch and raise her shoulder to protect her ticklish neck and ear, got her giggling like Sophie. He set his plate down and wrapped his arms around her. “Fuck, I love you so much,” he said, and hugged her until she grunted.



Twenty minutes of cardio, and forty minutes of lifting weights on the machines had the malaise within her stretched thinner. Not eased away, still present; like a knot tightened below her stomach had gone looser.

It was the worst day. A discombobulated mess of emotions brought on by a man who didn’t mean anything to her. Fear he would show up. Ameliorated by thoughts of a possible high-paying job offer. Fear her consideration of this imaginary job offer may be some secret facet of herself interested in Devlin showing up. But she wasn’t interested in Devlin. Hated him. Then, when she wasn’t fearful, she grumbled. Hating that this man could hijack her simple life so heartily . . . More thoughts of the benefit a job like Devlin could offer might bring . . . Then the rational side of herself saying Why

don't you go out and get one, then? Jesus, Kimmy. I mean, if you wanted more pay than the immigration firm then go out and look for something. When she thought she may be too hard on herself she considered Well, this job is right in front of you. Probably. But could you picture working with Devlin? You know what that would be like. A nightmare. No way around it. The work would be fine, but can you imagine what you'd have to endure? You know his opinions. And if you don't think you'd be fighting off his advances on the daily, you're crazy. Then, a slithering thought: Are you sure you'd be fighting, Kimmy? She would.

A sensibility had been returned to her. Yes, she'd done things with Devlin. Yes, more than once. Yes, those things could end her marriage. But the path had been righted, and she and Josh were tighter than ever. Everything she'd said to Karina about her and Josh was true. That's how she could tempt herself with the thought she could work for Devlin and resist him. Resist him? Sure. It's not like he was irresistible. She didn't even like him. Of course that dirty track had been already greased. With what she'd already permitted, how would she embark on a relationship that prohibited flirting. Or worse . . .

Jesus, Kimmy, Devlin'd move on to some other conquest after a while.

What?—so now you're considering this job not even officially offered? No. But maybe.

Really? . . .

It was like this all day.

She'd had to get out of the apartment, like the apartment was the source of these relentless non-sequiturs and the self-analysis.

Even out of the apartment she couldn't escape the pestering thoughts.

The worst? An analysis while she sat on a bench in the sunny park and watched some kids play on the jungle gym. Would her marriage survive a tryst with Devlin? If Josh found out what they'd really done, would he leave her? She wouldn't blame him. It would crush her to death, but she

wouldn't blame him. All their friends would find out. They'd blame her. Of course, who else could they blame? It's not like Josh disappointed her in any way. Not at all. Supportive and caring; the guy would move a mountain for her if she asked. Would Josh stay with you? Maybe. Look how he reacted when you gave him a glimpse of what happened at Tiffany's. Would he stay with you if you'd gone further? . . . Would he stay with you if you had an affair? I mean, it would be clear to him it wasn't emotional. And weren't emotional affairs the most hurtful?

That line of personal questioning had got her off the bench and walking, trying to escape her own quisling brain.

Physical affairs, affairs based solely on sex weren't hurtful? Was that something a part of her brain had armed itself with? And for what reason? Do you really, honest-to-god want to have sex with Devlin? That pompous privileged piece of shit . . . ?

No. She didn't.

It was something she could think about, and leave it at that.

Now she was at the fountain, taking a long drink, some fifty-year-old guy behind her with cutoff sleeves and gloves on waiting like she was taking too long. She let him in, backhanding water off her lower lip and nodding politely, the guy not giving her anything in return. Typical.

It was Devlin's fault, applying all this pressure on her. Pushing, pushing, pushing. Taunting. Kissing her. Pinning her down and humping his cock into her stomach. Humping it between her legs. That huge urgent cock.

Like you don't think about how it would be. All that Amy says, all she's tried to make come alive, it never crosses your mind what it would be like to have sex with a guy like that? . . . Yeah, but here's the thing. You're twenty-eight now. You're married. You have a good sex life with a man that loves you. Amy says you only think you have a good sex life. Saw Josh's erection, later said to her You poor unsatisfied thing, getting Devlin in on it. Like it was high school again.

No. She was no one's game piece. No one's toy. Too smart for that.

By the time she was passing through the doors to the women's locker room, she had a nice old mad-on happening. At her locker she drew out her phone and her shower kit. She undressed, wrapped herself in a towel, the black face of her phone staring at her. Inviting her.

She sat down, hunched with the phone held in two hands. Fuck you, Devlin. You don't win. She texted.

Kimmy: sorry I was out today

Kimmy: hope you didn't waste your time

Soon as she sent it, sitting on the bench wearing only a towel as two older women undressed behind her, coming in for the evening yoga class, she regretted it. But then seriously, fuck you, Devlin. She'd got herself out of the apartment, avoided his advances. He'd made her do that. Embedded in her life now.

When no text returned, she whispered, "Good," stood and put the phone in her locker, closed it, headed to the shower.

Half way there she heard a ding. Maybe her phone. Probably should ignore it, but she returned to her locker.

Devlin: couldn't make it

Devlin: in TO all day today

“Good for you,” she said to her phone. Another text came in.

Devlin: guess you're not interested

She said, “What do you think?” Did he mean the job? Interested in what?

Kimmy: You can't give me what I want

Meaning the job. Was this a negotiation?

Devlin: you don't know that

Maybe it was a negotiation. It didn't matter.

Kimmy: you'll never know

Devlin: sounds like I should have made our appointment

Now she scoffed. The nerve of this guy.

Kimmy: we didn't have an appointment

Kimmy: if we did I'd be there

Kimmy: I think our negotiations are done

Devlin: negotiations? I like it

Devlin: you sound sore

She scoffed louder, the sound echoing in the high metal rafters.

Kimmy: not sore

Kimmy: done

Kimmy: I'm at the gym with way better things to do with my time

Kimmy: so done with playing your games

Devlin: we only started 😞

“You’re such an asshole,” she whispered, shaking her head.

Kimmy: guess you don’t have all you thought 😞

“Fucking prick.” She placed her phone in the top shelf of her locker. It dinged again. She faced it to her.

Devlin: sounds like we should talk

“Nope, it doesn’t, my man,” she said, let the phone down, closed her locker and headed to the showers. Typical Devlin. Elliptical, back to the start. If you start with him, he’ll just keep you running around, and every time he doesn’t get what he wants, he’ll pop your game piece back at the start again, make you run his course till he gets it from you. There was no way he didn’t come by the apartment today. Wished she could get the security cam access so she could embarrass him, send him a still of his arrogant ass ringing her buzzer, her not answering. Could picture it now, him in the lobby, wearing sunglasses, not getting what he wants. But he looks up to the security cam, knowing somehow she’s watching. He winks.

“Such a fucking asshole,” she laughed, levering the shower to near full hot. Now she couldn’t stop laughing at herself, at how mad she was. All the swearing, a snide exchange with a guy like Devlin. He really winds your crank, Kimmy, doesn’t he? Consumes your thoughts. “Such an asshole,”

she whispered under the water's hiss. Cleaning herself, running soap over her wet naked body, lean and exercised, not looking too bad. Not bad at all. Better than those girls from high school, and she hadn't needed Devlin to point it out.

It was nice to hear. Nice to know your worth on the market.

When she returned to the locker, towel-wrapped, hair tied up, she checked her phone.

Devlin: tell you what

Devlin: back to Kingston, on the road now

Devlin: passing Pickering

Shit.

Devlin: You at the Jump Start Complex on Maitland right?

Devlin: Nav says I'll be there in twenty. Bet I'll be there in fifteen

"Fuck no," she sighed, mind racing, thumping down to sit on the bench staring at her phone. The message came ten minutes ago . . .

War Games

In the kitchen opening a bag of Zesty Cheese Doritos, Steve joined Josh, looking to pop the first beer of the night. Meyer was working on convincing sleepy Sophie to pack it in for the night, go have a lie-down on her Auntie Kimmy's bed. Sophie was tired but amped. One soda pop and that cute little girl was all live-wire energy, boogying away for her dance game, loving all the attention and getting laughs from her Uncle Josh, whom she adored. But Soph was on the precipice edge of a big fall, standing on that cliff edge of hearty uncompromising sleep. About a second away from falling face-down on the couch and being carted to bed. Meyer was putting smart choices in his daughter's repertoire, sweet-talking adult logic to a kid who wanted to party still.

"Am I crazy, or is Soph the cutest kid you've ever seen?" Steve was at his side, both of them watching Meyer's daughter listening patiently to her father's reasoning.

Josh said, "I know. She's so adorable."

"You guys trying again?"

"Me and Kimmy? It's on the table. Kimmy's thinking about working, too."

Steve put three bottles of Heineken on the counter without making them rattle, alcoholic beverages at the ready for when Sophie went to bed. Josh poured Doritos from the bag to a big serving bowl. Steve said, "I gotta get a girlfriend."

Josh laughed; Meyer took Sophie by the hand walking her past the pass-through, winking, joyless Sophie surrendering and wishing Josh and Steve a

polite good night, both of them leaning over the counter, singing G'night Sophie, waving, getting a little smirk from her. Josh went through the roster of the available girls in their age group who worked with them at Swanson, but the numbers were slim. Steve shot them down. Josh told him to join a gym or something, take up a hobby he'd like a girl to have. They popped the tops on their beers and took swigs.

“Hey,” Steve said, “whatever happened with that thing with Kimmy?”

“What thing with Kimmy?”

“You know, where you said she was with that guy when you were passed out. The guy from high school, at your guys's reunion.”

And just like that, his evening went grim. He hid it from his face, but shrugged for Steve's sake, like it was nothing, not like the big weight on his back he sometimes pretended it wasn't. It was hearing someone else bring it up out of the ether, talking life into a thing he could sometimes say was just his imagination. It had been shoved to the back of his closet, but now it toppled forward and landed on his toe. “Imagination is funny, you know how it is.”

“Good,” Steve said, taking another swig. “I hated to think something like that could be real.”

“You were the one who said—”

Meyer appeared on the other side of the counter, reaching for his Heineken and saying, “What could be real?”

Steve didn't want to say, so he plugged the bottle end in his mouth and drank, leaving it to Josh. Josh waffled, said, “Uh, this thing I told him . . .” Then couldn't finish.

Steve swallowed, looked to Meyer who popped his own beer, standing on the other side of the counter looking perplexed and maybe a little left out. Steve said to Meyer, “Your cuz is a worry wart for no reason.”

Meyer nodded, chuckled, drank.

Josh said, "It's nothing. Kimmy . . ."

Meyer was interested, leaning elbows on the counter top.

Steve said, "Josh went to that high school reunion."

Meyer said, "Yeah, I know. He drank too much, passed out. He told me."

Josh said, "When I was out, Kimmy maybe got in, like, a fight with someone."

Meyer tried not to laugh, then saw Josh was serious. "You mean like a fist fight?"

"Yeah."

Steve said, "With a guy."

Meyer said, "What guy?"

Josh said, "You remember Devlin from my high school?"

"No . . . Maybe. Jock or something?"

"Right."

Meyer said, "Why did she get in a fight with this guy?"

Steve said, "Kimmy wouldn't tell him."

Meyer said, "That's weird."

"No, she did," Josh said. "Eventually."

Steve said, "Oh yeah? You didn't tell me. Why?"

“I can’t say. It’s Kimmy’s biz. I don’t want to talk about it, guys, can we just play some Modern Warfare, please?” He nodded his chin to the TV where the menu for Sophie’s dancing game still swirled.

“Yeah, yeah,” Steve said. “So it was a fight? Not something else?”

Meyer said, “Something else?”

Josh waved the conversation away, grabbing the bowl of chips and his beer.

Meyer said to Steve, “Something else, something else? . . .”

Steve said, “Told you your cuz is a worry wart.”

On the couch, Meyer was still interested. “Josh, you think it was something else?”

“I don’t want to talk about it. Look, Kimmy and I worked it out. It was nothing. Well, no, not nothing, but Kimmy and I dealt with it.”

The worry on Meyer’s face bothered him. And he hated to have his cousin thinking bad of Kimmy. “It’s fine, Meyer, I mean it, really. Kimmy and I . . . this week we’ve never been better.”

Meyer looked unconvinced but knew he had to let it go. Steve broke the uncomfortable silence with some eager pre-game hype man talk, firing up Modern Warfare. Then farting. Meyer laughed.

But Josh was thinking now how Kimmy’d been out of sorts when they got home. How she’d wanted the car today. Why? So he wouldn’t show up at home at lunchtime unannounced? Had Devlin been here today, fucking her on their bed? Kimmy was all tired out, had to have a nap in the afternoon and recover from the big-dick pounding Devlin gave her. Her demeanor when he’d arrived home replayed in his head, and now he attributed guilt to everything she did and everything she’d said. Couldn’t hang out and talk with them for too long, the guilt was so strong, Kimmy not able to meet his cousin’s eyes knowing what she’d done today with another man, how she’d betrayed Josh . . .

Or it was nothing.

This was over. It was supposed to be behind him. But the all-consuming thoughts returned.

Five minutes later, he'd excused himself from the room to go to the can, sitting now on the toilet so he could fire up Find My Phone . . .



With the hatch of the Qashqai open, headlights from behind beamed her shadow over the cargo area. She tossed in her purse, her bag, then slammed the hatch door down as the headlights careened sideways and the car pulled up to stop. She turned. It was Devlin.

He sat low in his Mercedes, his big frame filling up the cockpit, elbow on the door sill. Smirking at her, his cheek dimpled. "Told you fifteen." The depth of his voice made the words decipherable even over the music coming from his stereo.

She was sure to show her unimpressed face for a long beat, waiting for him to turn the stereo down. When he did, she said, "I don't know if you're looking for a gold star or what . . ."

But if she thought she had him, she didn't. He said, "I get a gold star from you it won't be for finishing fast."

She chuckled, not at the joke—it was juvenile—but at his ability to disarm. She could rail now, tell him he's a pig, but it was probably what he wanted. She said, "What do you want, Devlin? It's late. I'm on my way home."

"Not even nine, Kimmy," he said. "Not late. Night's just getting started."

“Maybe for you, Devlin, but I was on my way home. I appreciate you coming by, but I think if anything needs to be said between us in the future, we can do that by text. But I don’t even see a reason for that.”

“You don’t?”

“Do you?” She crossed her arms, leaned her butt against the back of the Nissan.

He didn’t answer, dipping his head out of the reddish light from the gym’s wall-mounted sign way above and behind her. She swore he was ruffling his hair, checking himself out in the rearview mirror. When his face reappeared in the open car window, his dashing smile was wide. “Give me five. We’ll go up the road, find some place serves a half decent Scotch, and I’ll tell you all I can offer.”

“I know what you offer.”

His smile faltered. Returned. “You don’t want it?”

“Don’t need it, thanks.”

He raised his eyebrows, made an interested sound in his throat. “Go back home. Back to your apartment. Back to the firm making what you make. Sleeping in the same bed, waking the same, never knowing the could-have-beens.”

Was he talking about a job or not? “Your first year psych 101 shit doesn’t work on me, Devlin. Nice try, though. I mean it.”

He laughed heartily, freely, a quick head toss back. “You’re a diamond, Kimmy,” he said.

“I am a diamond.”

The humor left his face a moment. His eyes traveled from her sneakers, up her yoga tights to her face. He smiled again, eyes narrowed. “You’re like a diamond in a greasy cardboard box someone brought home from the grocery, you in that apartment. So much. So wasted.”

“I’m not wasted, Devlin.”

“You know you’re not going to make baskets.”

“I’m not. I’m stopping.”

“So what are you going to do? Back to immigration? Linoleum floors, fluorescent lights, two weeks a year, hoping you have enough for Cuba?”

“Work is more than what you bring home.”

“Really?” He laughed now, watching a car coming behind, waiting to see if he’d have to move aside from the lane he was blocking, but the car pulling down an aisle on the prowl for a parking spot. “Your level of expertise, sitting five days a week, all that potential. To do what? Help someone get a leg up here? Die on your sword if you want, Kimmy. You’re too smart to fall for what you call my bullshit. But. But . . . you’re too smart to think I’m wrong, too.” He showed a snide flash of a smile, his eyes hidden in the shadow of his door frame, teeth lit in gym-light red.

She bounced off the Nissan lightly, arms still crossed, went to the Mercedes’s open window, peering inside his expensive car, all the gauges and dials, polished walnut and leather. “I tell you what, gold star. I’ll give you that five minutes if you use it to give it to me straight. For once, I’d like you to talk like you’re not dancing around something.”

All she wanted was some straightforward communication. This wasn’t sex. This wasn’t an affair. Tell me what you mean. Is there a job, or is all this a ploy to get me to open my legs? Because it won’t happen again . . .

They were in his Mercedes, a stupid thing for her to do, but it was too late now, sitting on the leather bucket chair next to Devlin, rocketing into Ajax proper. She wore her yoga tights, a tank top, a wide-bottom and short-cropped sweatshirt, and sneakers; purse between her feet. Devlin wearing most of a suit. Pants and belt, dress shirt, no tie, cuffs unbuttoned, sleeves rolled up. His forearms were hairy. Black hair. Muscular too. More than in high school. Mature muscle.

Devlin said, “Where’s there a bar around here?”

“I don’t know,” she said, shifting in her seat, looking around to get her bearings, thinking of the places out by the 401, all filled with too-young people, then thinking of the Dragon. Not far from where they lived, though. Pictured sitting at the bar, Josh, Meyer, and Steve coming in for a drink, seeing her there, the shock on her face. But, no. Not with Sophie. Sophie in bed, it was past her bedtime, they wouldn’t bring her nor leave her at home. Call a sitter so they can go to the bar? Those three playing Modern Warfare, beers in the fridge, stomachs full of pizza, looking to go out of the apartment for a drink? Not in a million years . . .

“Turn right up ahead,” she said, “then a left. I’ll show you. There’s a pub . . .”

“Place where we can talk?”

“So you do want to talk?”

“Kimmy’s telling me she wants to hear it straight, doesn’t want to dance anymore,” he said aloud like to himself. “Let’s sit down, see what I say . . .”

“Why don’t you show me some respect? You say I’m so much better than all those girls from high school, yet you talk to me like I’m one of them. Like I’m some bimbo who’s going to eat out of your hand.”

“I don’t talk to you like that.”

“You do, Devlin. Everything is like you want to get in my pants.”

He turned his face to hers, mocking an uh-oh expression, the passing streetlights flickering on the ridges of his cheekbones.

It was surprisingly comical. Not arrogant for once, but personable. She laughed. Then he did too. She said, “That’s all you want? Get in my pants? You really are an asshole.”

He laughed still, eyes on the road, a calmness loosening his features, still in the joke, even enjoying her messing with him. “Your pussy is just a piece of

pie in the bakery, Kimmy.”

The tone of his voice was calm, unprovocative. Not teasing her, maybe even in a way saying he didn’t want to get in her pants. He did, though. It was clear by his actions. And of course that he had already gotten in her pants. But if sex was only a piece of the puzzle, what was the whole picture?

There was fear walking from Devlin’s Mercedes to the Fox & Dragon she’d encounter Josh and Steve and Meyer. Or maybe another acquaintance. But there was no one. Late on a Tuesday night who would they run into? No one in Ajax knew Devlin. Few people in Ajax even knew her, and she lived here. Maybe someone from the building?

It didn’t matter; they saw no one on the street, and she got ahead, scanned the windows of the Dragon as they passed under the brick arch, coming to the empty patio. Inside the pub were no faces she knew. Only a half dozen patrons total, none of the crowd looking like people she would associate with.

They took seats at the very end of the bar so they could be alone, the nearest patrons congregated clear at the opposite end of the bar. She got on a stool, hooked her sneakers on its rung, swiveled and watched Devlin take his spot next to her. His eyes were down low, and when he sidled next to her, sitting open, fucking man-spreading with his knees out wide like a pair of wings, he said, “What do you do at the gym? Yoga or something?”

“Gym stuff. Treadmill, weights. I do yoga once a week.”

“It’s working.” He put a hand on his hip, suit jacket open, white shirt tight against his hard belly, waving to the bartender.

She said, “What, were you checking me out the whole way here? I knew I should have let you walk out front.”

“Yeah, but you had to keep an eye out for people you knew,” he said, and before she could interject the bartender was there. Devlin said, “Best Scotch?”

The guy nodded, assessing Devlin, taking it all in. The expensive watch, the stare, the expensive suit, the build . . . If Josh were so brusque, the bartender would come back at him passive-aggressive. This guy just smiled, said, “Oban. Not the highest shelf in the world, but you can’t tell me it’s not great.”

Devlin said, “Two doubles,” and the bartender got to pouring.

She said, “Think I’m a Scotch drinker?”

He leaned a forearm on the padded edge of the bar saying, “I think you like nice things. I think you’re interested in what a good Scotch tastes like.”

“I’ve had Scotch before.”

“Indulge me. You want something else?”

“Scotch is fine,” she said.

The bartender set low glasses with an inch of amber whisky in the bottoms. Devlin lay down two twenties and waved off change. He picked up his glass and held it out. She collected hers, met his, they touched glass. Devlin said, “To the beginning,” and sipped his Scotch.

She tasted her Oban, hid a grimace, set the glass down on the chipped bar counter’s Newcastle coaster. “The beginning of what?”

He said, “The beginning of something incredible.”

“This is what I’m talking about, Devlin,” she said, her voice edged with irritation. “Treat me with respect. I don’t like this double talk and innuendo. It’s not me. I’m not one of those girls. You want to begin something with me, you’re going to make it clear. Do you understand?”

He flashed that mean smile. Mean but gleeful. “More I talk to you, Kimmy, the more I know I found a killer. Someone like me.”

“I’m not a killer, and I’m nothing like you.”

“You don’t even know,” he said, smug. Like she wasn’t aware yet, but he was right.

“What did you bring me here for? You still can’t say. More I talk to you, the more I think you’re just that: talk.” She sipped more Oban, prepared for it now, not minding its hot bite. Devlin joined her, then set his glass down.

“Alright. You want it straight. I’ll tell you.” He paused for dramatic effect.

She regarded him with lazy, hooded eyes. “Hit me.”

“Two minutes from now I’m going to offer you a job. Lawyer job. One you’d be crazy not to take. You’re going to take it. Not tonight, but you’ll call me in a day, tell me it’s a deal. You want to talk to Josh first.”

“So this is about a job after all?” A tingle of excitement began, imagining the challenge of a new endeavor, of making money.

He undid another button on his dress shirt, showing her the base of his neck, tilting his jaw so she could see the stretch from his collar bone to his ear, shaded with stubble this late in the day, the tendons and cords standing out. “Thirty minutes from now, Kimmy, I’m going to have you on a hotel bed.” He touched his neck with an index finger. “Fucking you deep. You’re going to come, you’re going to scream, you’re going to bite me here”—he tapped the finger to a spot on his neck—“Tell me I’m wrong.”

It was a surprise. She’d asked for honesty and he’d delivered it. What he wanted wasn’t unexpected. She couldn’t even be mad. That was what she knew he’d say. “You’re wrong. That’s how you offer a job? Tell me I have to fuck you?”

“Not at all. The two are separate. Work for me. Fuck me three times a week. That’s what I want. You wanted to know, so there it is. You asked if I was watching you walk ahead of me? Yes. I watched your ass, and I pictured you on all fours, my view, your ass, fucking you doggy.”

“You’re disgusting. I have to fuck you for this job?”

“No. We’re going to fuck because you want it as bad as me. Fight it if you want. Take the job, never fuck me. No big deal. I’m not trying to date you, marry you . . . I want to fuck you. Say no.” He touched a napkin closer, reached in his suit jacket and withdrew a fat black pen, a Mont Blanc. He scribbled on the blank side of the napkin and presented it to her, returning his pen to an interior pocket. “You have everything I want. That’s innuendo, I know. I’m talking about a smart woman, really fucking deadly smart, treading water presently but oh-so-hungry. Went to Queens, went to Western. Speaks Chinese. That’s what I offer that caliber.”

She read the number. Three-point-eight-something times more than what they paid at the immigration firm. “That’s a lot of money.” Her heart raced with the number. Knew she was worth it.

“Lot of responsibility. It’s not easy. High pressure sometimes. High stakes. I need someone who isn’t a fuck up. Kimmy Chang is goddam perfect.”

“Waters. Kimmy Waters.”

“You’re Kimmy Chang when you work for me.”

“You want to see a Chinese name on your roster.”

“Not me. Everyone else.”

“That’s all I am?”

“Chinese? No. Told you about that bakery.”

She huffed a small laugh, any snide answer deadened by the big number with the dollar sign scrawled across the napkin. A lawyer. Chinese. Smart. Beautiful. Better than those other girls. And he wanted her pussy. “I’ll have to think about it,” she said, pushing away the napkin.

“You’ll take it. You’ll call me tomorrow, tell me you want it. Too smart. You just gotta talk to Joshy first.”

“I do.”

“Want me to talk to him?”

“I do not.”

“Good. I’m glad. We’re done, Kimmy, that’s it. The beginning. Finish your drink. I want to get your hot naked ass on that hotel bed.”

Dragon's Den

A ringing in his ears accompanied Josh from the secret spy lair of the bathroom; heart-thudding he returned stiffly to the couch where Steve and Meyer were engaged in an assault on the landlord Almalik, Meyer in control, Steve offering support.

They played, he watched vacantly; explosions, gunfire, yelling, dying, his friends cheering. An empty feeling spread from his core, a lone figure in an endless void.

How had it come to this?

He'd sat on the toilet and spied on Kimmy. No big deal. He'd spied on her a lot with Find My Phone. Liked to know where she was. That she was safe. Tonight he'd spied on her to catch her in a lie.

And what had he discovered?

He watched that pinging blue dot on the map; expecting to see her location not where she'd said. He'd worried he'd find her lying to him. The dot showed her location outside the gym. Where she should be.

It should have been happy news. It deserved a fist pump. But instead he wasn't satisfied. And truthfully a small measurement of disappointment could be detected. The truth of the pinging dot was resisted: he told himself these things could be inaccurate . . .

What kind of thought was that?

Don't you want her to be at the gym?

Of course he did. Devlin had got into his head, made him doubt her. He shouldn't have been spying on her in the first place. To find her where she said she'd be should have been good news, but he faced it with incredulity.

Fucking Devlin Stone. Master manipulator.

Got him doubting his own wife. Got him spying from secret locations . . . mistrusting the love of his life.

It was an insidious ploy.

The power was in his hands though. Reject Devlin, don't fall for the poisonous doubt. If you did, you were his pawn. Trust Kimmy. It was there on the phone's screen. Kimmy was at the gym. Stop the madness.

"You okay?"

He looked up to see Meyer watching him, game paused, Steve smirking.

Meyer said, "You look like you saw a ghost."

"You're so pale for the summer," Steve said.

Josh laughed, shook off the badness, reached for his beer and swigged. "I'm sick of watching you flounce around taking potshots and hiding. Could I have the controller, please?—it's time for you two to see how it's done . . ."



For minutes now her breath had come only in small hitches. Brief breath in, brief breath out; ribs hardly moving at all. Like the act of breathing was a disruption, and if the current state was dispelled she'd have to confront this new strange reality. A job offer. A real one. Real money. She didn't want it dispelled. Now it was on the table, she wanted to look at it. Count it.

Disruption would bring another reality she needed to face (and didn't want to).

You can't seriously consider this job offer, can you?

On the heels of the offer, your potential boss firmly presented the plan to go to a hotel room and have sex. You're not even hired yet and this is his behavior. You'd be crazy to work for Devlin Stone. But the money . . .

Then get another job, Kimmy.

But this was here and now. She could be working in a week, money coming in the bank . . . The things she and Josh could do . . . Her family . . . Take her dad to Taiwan to see relatives. She and Josh could take their own vacations, too, places they'd always wanted to see but seemed too extravagant. Clothes, eating out . . . Savings. Buy a home . . . Sure, she could get a high-paying job on her own. One that had nothing to do with Devlin. She was qualified. (Of course, she'd been dormant, and they might ask why she'd spent so many years working the low-paying job in immigration.) This job was right here, in her lap . . .

She could handle Devlin Stone. Handle him despite the past transgressions. Couldn't she?

Devlin stood aside of her for the moment, on the top step of the Dragon's patio, pausing for what he told her was an important call. She waited below, hugging arms around herself, sneaker toe kicking at the raised lip of a heaved red brick in the walkway that ran to the closed shops on the right, the path under the archway and out to the street on her left.

Even the pose her potential boss struck was the epitome of arrogant masculinity. Totally blocking the short set of steps should anyone wish to pass; one hand on hip, the hand in a fist; chest out, feet shoulder width apart. Devlin talked into the phone in a deep resonant tone, telling someone on the other side "that was the way it was always going to be, and if Cruickshank didn't know that he deserved the consequences. I save my sympathy for smart people." He gave a ciao, Bud, closed off the call and

tucked the phone in his suit jacket before trotting down to join her saying, “Sorry about that.”

“I’m fine,” she said, gaze lingering aside to the lit storefront of a closed woman’s shop, halogen spotlight on a porcelain white mannequin, headless, showing off a long black skirt and sleeveless sweater. First thing she would do was buy a new suit. In black or steel. Shoes, too, pointed toes.

“You ready to get out of here?”

“I am,” she said, letting him lead the way.

Devlin said, “Hotels are shit in Ajax. But we can find some flop house with a bed.” He half-turned, waiting for her to catch up.

She chuckled, his persistence amusing. It was a taunt, not a command he issued. Practically in jest. She could choose to be offended—and wouldn’t be wrong—or ignore it. She said, “You’re such an asshole.”

“Twenty-four-seven, Miss Chang, you don’t even know half of it.”

“I’m not changing my name— For your information. And I’m married.”

As they passed beneath the brick arch a group of three headed to the Dragon turned from the sidewalk and walked toward them. Her heart jumped, and that fear of being caught alarmed her. She wandered aside to stand in the shadows under the canopy of a low locust tree. Devlin pivoted, came her way. He watched over his shoulder, hands in pockets; the three passed and they weren’t familiar to her anyway.

Now Devlin faced her, closed her off under the bush, blocking her path. He was tall. Wide shouldered. He smelled like sandalwood and pine. “That was close,” he said, restrained mirth in his tone. “You know them?”

“No,” she said, relaxing. “Look . . .”

He checked his watch.

“I’m not taking any job where you think you can force me into having sex.”

“I’d never force you.”

“Coerce. Wrangle. Whatever. If you’re offering me this job so you can have sex with me . . .”

“Please, Kimmy,” he said, scoffing. Both his hands in his pockets, he said, “That’s a lot of money I put in front of you. If all I wanted was sex what kind of loser would I be hiring you? You know what I mean? I’m not old, not fat, not ugly. I’ve got a good head of hair. I could get you in bed without dropping a dime— I know, I know, I’m a pig.” He put up his huge hands in defense now like he expected her to take a swipe at him, but she was still listening. “If I was the kind of man who spent money like that on a piece of pussy I’d go to Vegas, get a girl for ten-grand looks just like you. The whole weekend. Get it out of my system. The job offer is because I went to school with you. I know what kind of student you were. Extrapolate that through Queens and Western . . .? Then this fucking fire you show me. At Tiffany’s . . .? That’s fire. And I’m not talking about how I almost got my dick in you, I’m talking how you don’t back down.”

“When I’m motivated.”

“I was a dick. It’s fun to prod you. See what you’ll say.”

“Then you’re diagnosable.”

“You’re not wrong,” he said laughing. “Shit I went through, fuck, the things I’ve done. Yeah, certifiable is more like it. But, listen: I’m offering Kimmy Chang—oh, excuse me, Kimmy Waters—a good job because I need her to fill it. Sex and job are like this—” He made large fists, separated them out either side of him—“Two different things. I’m hiring you. We have an existing relationship. Whether you like it or not. From high school to last week, you and I aren’t exactly unknown to each other sexually. We have a past. Not a big deal, but it’s not like we’re strangers. I want to fuck you. That’s not going to change. Come work for me see what happens. You never want it, cool. Trust me, it’s cool. We fuck, we don’t fuck . . . that’s up to you. But it doesn’t have a thing with why I want to hire you nor does it have anything to do with you keeping the job. The only requirement from you is that Kimmy Chang brain and that fire— Can you give me that?”

She surmised him a long while, sucking on her cheek, her crossed arms tightened. His face was hidden in shadow, a shimmering streetlight painting a stripe along his prominent cheekbone, his hard jaw, the brushed back hair gleaming like it was wet. She muttered, "It's off the table, anyway."

"Anyway?"

"You know . . ."

"It's up to you."

She chuckled, not wanting to have to explain it and now faced with it. "You know, we already know." She leaned closer, arms still crossed, whispering, "You didn't exactly fit."

"Oh," he said, laughing. "I fit, Kimmy. Be real. If we weren't in the grass, if I wasn't trying to go up your shorts leg . . . if we didn't have your friends breathing down our neck . . .?"

"Like if we had a hotel room?"

"You me, right now."

"You know that's not going to happen, Devlin."

"I'm letting you know I'm available."

"Like I ever thought you weren't."

"Seriously, Kimmy. I need a good, smart lawyer. That's you. You and I have unfinished business I'd like to see finished. Tell me to keep my mouth shut, it's shut. Okay?"

She said, "Keep your mouth shut."

He nodded (and she could tell he was still smiling). "Take the job first."

It made her laugh, and she growled, grabbed her bangs and hid her face, saying into her wrist, "You're so infuriating."

“Sue me, counselor— Kimmy Chang gets mad she likes to fuck.”

That wasn't as funny, but when she looked up he'd left her, out on the walkway again, hands in his pockets, cutting a roguish silhouette in the street lamps' glow. She sighed, came out to join him.

They walked side by side without saying more, getting to his Mercedes parked street side in a long line of cars. He unlocked it with his fob, the lights flashing; he held the door for her.

As she stepped under his chin, looking to get in the seat, he said, “Where we headed—the gym or the Holiday Inn?”

She stopped, folded her arms again, leaned her shoulders against the roofline of his car looking up at him. “I take the job you swear you'll leave me alone if I ask?”

“If you ask,” he said, coming into her space, the two of them in the V of his open door, her shoes on the street, his on the sidewalk, towering over her.

She showed him a grim expression, like she was contemplating. Then he stooped. Her head darted back as his face got nearer to hers like he would kiss her. She raised her crossed arms as a barrier between them, turned her face away and showed him her cheek. He stayed near. She faced him. “Don't ever try to kiss me.”

He breathed slowly, calmly; stayed near, still stooped. He set a foot down so he was lower. His huge hand spread on her stomach then slid down the front of her tights, smoothing over the stretchy fabric, his fingers scooping under her crotch. She grunted and moaned; her knees weakened. His hand pulled upward, almost lifting her; she went on her toes. The firmness of his palm against her sex sent a sparkle through the back of her brain like glitter tossed past a flashlight. He smiled and she was mad and she thought about kneeling his balls. Thought about grabbing them. Knew he'd be hard; she'd feel that python on her wrist . . .

“Don't,” she whispered.

“Your pussy’s so hot right now,” he said in a low growl. “I can feel the heat through your tights.”

“Don’t touch me there anymore,” she whined.

“I know you want my fingers inside you, I know you want to come, give me that tonight. For your own sake.” He chuckled, slid his hand up the flat of her stomach, stepped back onto the sidewalk and widened the door.

She stared at him, incredulous. How could he be so bold? And he was pleased with himself, smiling, knowing his effect. And the effect was real. Her cheeks burned right now, a sizzling rash on the back of her neck; her nipples ached. Without looking, she knew they’d poked out the front of her jersey. And between her legs, she could feel the dampness. Devlin’d said she felt like an overripe peach when he’d fingered her in her apartment hallway. It was probably apt.

He said, “You getting in?”

She took her eyes off his, unnerved into silence, and backed into his Mercedes. He closed her door.

Cockpit

When Devlin sat in the driver's seat, she was on him. "I have to get home to my husband, Devlin."

"You going to talk to him about work?"

"Not tonight. . . . No, I don't know. Maybe tonight."

Devlin nodded, not starting the car yet. He checked his watch, looked her way.

"It's late," she said.

"Not that late. What's Joshy doing tonight?"

"He's got friends over."

"Playing magic cards or whatever?"

She laughed. "You're such a dick."

He smiled, stared in her eyes. "He probably won't notice you're late."

"Not if you take me back to my car now."

"I thought you'd be smart enough to grab something good when it's right in front of you."

"I am . . ."

He pushed the start on his Roadster and it roared to life, all the gauges lighting up, powerful engine throbbing somewhere ahead of them, muffled but threatening.

She said, “Josh would notice I’m late. Trust me. What would I even tell him?” She’d meant to point out how ridiculous it was to consider going to a hotel, but the words in the air sounded like she’d given an inch of the battlefield, surrendered some of her territory.

“Tell him you went out for a drink.”

She laughed. “With you?”

“How about Amy? Call her. She’ll back you up.”

“I left my phone in my car.”

“Hm,” he nodded. “No one knows where you are.”

In a newscaster’s voice, she said, “Kimmy Waters was last seen in the vicinity of the Jump Start Complex—”

“Nipples pressing out her shirt,” he finished, and put the car in gear.

She startled, looked down, saw indeed the front of her sweater’d been humped out with two large bolts. She crossed her arms, said, “I can’t even believe I’m sitting with you.”

“You’ve been fighting it since fucking high school, Kimmy, it’s frustrating to watch you flummox around, act like you don’t want it.”

She scoffed. “Can’t even believe I’m considering working with you.”

“For me. Under me . . .”

“Trying to scare me off?”

Devlin raced around a slower car, then darted in between two pickups. The Mercedes moved effortlessly, but a sideways glance to the digital readout

on his cockpit showed they were doing double the speed limit.

“Kimmy, if I thought you scared so easy, were so timid, I wouldn’t give you the time of day.” He turned right onto Stinson, a four-way, hotels on the left as you neared the highway, but the gym up ahead.

She laughed, said, “Looks like you were too chicken to take me to the Holiday Inn.”

He snapped a look her way, mean, devilish, but also amused. He said, “I can do what I need to do right here in this seat.” His hand came to her side; she watched it settle on her thigh, just above her knee. His hand looked so large on her slender leg.

With both her hands she took hold of his fingers and thumb, removing his grip from her knee, putting his hand back on his side like it was something unclean she’d found in the kitchen, saying, “I wouldn’t do it willingly.”

“I can play it that way,” he said smugly.

She crossed her arms again, covering the showing bulbs of her nipples, both of them smirking as he pulled into the gym complex, her Qashqai parked right up front of the boxy concrete complex (open twenty-four hours and still lively with gym-goers). She said, “Amy’s in England, anyway.”

A quick glance her way, and now he was pulling away from her vehicle, slowly heading into the deep maze of parking outside the complex.

She laughed, said, “You can let me out now. My car’s back there . . .” She thumbed over her shoulder.

Devlin said, “Amy’s still in T.O.; she’s home another week. If Josh asked, she’d tell him she’s in town and you two went out for drinks.”

“That’s stupid,” she said. “And then Amy would know.”

“Does that matter? You’d tell her what we did anyway.”

“Maybe. I might not though . . .”

“Want me to call her?”

She laughed. “So we can go to a hotel room? Get real.”

“Told you, I can do it from this seat,” he said, palming his own thigh and nosing the Roadster into a parking spot at the very back of the lot, facing the passing traffic on Stinson just beyond a grassy barrier planted with young trees.

“With all these people around?” She stiffened her folded arms, a chill tightening her skin, up the back of her neck; her nipples hardened like they would burst. She shivered and it alleviated the discomfort.

Devlin said, “You know I’m not shy. Neither are you.”

She grunted, looking left and right as cars passed ahead of them, beyond the trees, lights on, the early night dark blue. At the party, Devlin’d riled her. Humped himself between her legs and got her wanting him in a way she’d never felt before. Then in the apartment, the same thing. There to apologize, he’d ended up jabbing a hand down her pants and jacking her off. She did nothing to stop him. “What’s the job, anyway?”

He turned her way, drawing in a deep breath, exhaling slow, a somehow strangely sensual sound. “Counsel. Contracts. Travel. Advice. What do you think?”

“What kind of travel?”

“You mean where? China, India, Italy . . . Once a month, maybe more. Can you handle that?”

“And I’d be traveling with you?”

“And others.”

“What about time off?”

“Four weeks a year. Take off somewhere nice, take that scrawny husband of yours. Guy needs a tan.”

“It’d be nice,” she said, eyes out the window, picturing palm trees and beaches.

“I think I just made your life.”

She laughed, scratched at her neck where it was bare at the edge of her sweater. “No, you didn’t.”

“You can have it all, Kimmy. Your husband for whatever reason, a great job that challenges you, makes you worthwhile, an income, travel, vacations . . . It’s hard work with me but it’s fun too. You and I mess around a little and Josh never has to know.”

“You’re hilarious.” Big eye roll for him to see.

“I’m fun, Kimmy. For real. Hey, look at me . . .” She did, one side of his rugged face lit up with the light from the dash of his expensive Roadster, sitting there offering her things she wanted, tempting her with things she shouldn’t have. “Fucking everybody and their cousin messes around. It’s no big deal, you know it. Just a bit of fun, blow off steam, get it a little different. You deserve it.”

She laughed out loud, drew in a long breath, shaking her head, tracing her fingers on her neck. “You ever work so hard for it like this?”

“No,” he laughed along. “You’re worth it. You and I’ve been circling a long time. Yeah, I want it. You made me be honest—and I hate that—I told you what I want.”

She shook her head, like it was disbelief coursing through her, his ridiculous words—practically illicit. If he was going to be her boss he should never be talking like this.

But was it disbelief? This was Devlin at his core. And she was the one sitting here listening to his terrible prompts. Considering the job, actually really wanting it. And that other consideration: maybe she was curious.

He said, “Finish what we started. What Amy and I wanted, what you and I practically did . . . last Monday in your apartment, you didn’t stop me. I watched your face while I did it . . .” His voice had gone low, his patter undulating, almost hypnotic.

She said, “That’s what you want?” Her voice cracked and she cleared her throat with a quiet cough.

“That’s what you want, isn’t it?”

She regarded him; he watched her intently, looking so large in his small, sexy sports car. “What is?”

“To come. You want to come. Come hard—like the way your husband can’t do.”

“He makes me come, Devlin—God, I can’t believe the things you get me to say . . .”

He shifted in his seat, the rustling of his dress shirt loud as a snapping sail in the confines of the Mercedes. He wore the suit jacket now, unbuttoned and open, light picking off the bend in his belt buckle, getting closer, intent. His hand went over her thigh, just above her knee again, and her eyes lowered to it. That huge hand looked good on her skinny black-clad leg.

She said, “What do you think you’re doing?”

“I’m doing what I want—but this time I’m asking you.”

“Asking me . . .?”

“Tug your tights down. Close your eyes. I’m going to bring you off.”

“No, you’re not,” she said, trying to laugh, but her voice breaking, a weird fight or flight thing happening, getting her heart racing and putting a measure of fear in there as well. It felt wild and unsafe trapped in his car like this.

“Tug them down, Kimmy,” he said, his hand rising higher up her thigh, squeezing firm.

She stared at him, challenging him with her eyes, trying to show him that strong expression he said he liked. But it didn’t change the look in his eyes and she wondered if her face wasn’t lit. His sturdy grip shifted higher up her thigh, his fingers nudging the space where her upper thighs sealed together. She chuckled in her throat, shrugged a shoulder, thumbed out the front of her tights. “Go ahead,” she whispered, eyes on his.

But he didn’t jump right in; eyes locked on hers, he took his time releasing her seatbelt, clicking, pushing it away to retract. Then his hand was under her sweater, going flat on her stomach.

“I can’t wait to see your body,” he said. “You are fucking so beautiful.”

“Yeah?” she whispered, sinking into his leather seat, while his fingertips explored the hardness of her belly, teasing at her navel, driving her mad. With her pants tugged outward, she was desperate now to be touched.

“I want to get you all dressed up, take you out for dinner with clients, take you to Italy, fuck you how you need it . . .”

“I don’t need that,” she gasped.

His hand dragged downward, going way too slow, getting her squirming, knuckles flicking through her pubic hair now. Index finger curling, he stroked the apex of her sex. Even she heard the wet crackle.

“You can’t tell me you don’t need it when your pussy’s begging me to fuck it.”

“You’re so vulgar,” she said, closing her eyes, shifting in her seat, his finger making her crazy.

“I’m a bad man, Kimmy, and you love to hate me.”

“That’s true,” she said in a hiss, squeezing her ass muscles, wishing, hoping he’d put his finger inside her already.

“You told me you don’t want my lips on yours, but you can’t say you don’t want my cock.”

“I don’t,” she whispered in complaint. His fingers stroked and teased, slipping in, breaching her but not going deep; she rolled her hips forward trying to get penetration.

He gave it to her.

Two bundled fingers burrowed into her tight canal and she let out a satisfied groan that showed Devlin she was lying, betraying what she kept hidden. She wanted his cock. She was denying it, but she wanted it.

“Oh, ah, mm God,” she said, squinting, swiveling her hips. “You’re too big, Devlin . . .”

“Guess we’ll never know,” he said, steadily pulsing and caressing his fingers inside her, curling, stroking, touching an insane node on her front wall that had her legs jumping, a weird urge to pee storming through her, just a pretend, a tickle, a parrot miming another bird.

She grunted, gave a soft breathy laugh. “God, what are you doing to me?”

His voice was a gravelly whisper: “Giving you what you need—I love watching you while you get it.”

“Yeah, uh-huh, okay, give it to me,” she gasped, a release, loving hearing her own breathy voice making the request, being honest with him for the first time ever.

He tugged her crotch with his huge hand, hoisting her whole body, bringing her closer, wedging her ass in the corner of her seat, her shoulder touching his chest; the act drove his two large fingers deep inside her enough she let out a warbling wail.

“Yeah, you’re so fucking wet, Kimmy, so fucking wet. I could get inside you when you’re like this . . .”

“No,” she said, frowning. “I can’t do that . . .”

“I’m going to satisfy you in ways you didn’t know possible, Kimmy,” he rumbled, mouth very near her ear. His other hand cupped the back of her head, lowered and stroked her neck. Her chin dipped down; she saw her nipples again, lit in the car’s dash light like two sex beacons under the cotton, casting crescent shadows; saw her thumb hooking out her waistband, Devlin’s large hand shoved under there, under her panties. The sounds of wet suction from her sex drove her crazy; must drive him crazy too.

She whispered, “Are you hard?”

“So fucking hard for you right now, Kimmy, it’s ripping my pants.”

She chuckled, writhed her back against his chest, the center console of his Mercedes digging into the bottom of her ribcage. “Take it out . . .”

“I’ve got my hands full,” he grumbled, one between her legs, the other smoothing over her collar, fingers stroking an aching nipple.

Elbow dug back, she swiveled her forearm to his side, clawed hand finding the hardness of his muscular thigh. Devlin continued to fuck her with his big fingers, the thrusting going smooth and easy from her slickness. Her opening was over-lubricated, her body screaming for reproduction. “Ah, it feels, mm . . .” Her hips pulsed against his thrusts. Her right hand let the yoga pants’ waistband close, and then curled over the back of Devlin’s lusty hand, so large and hard under her palm. She squeezed, rubbed, held his wrist, thumb webbing bumping against his Rolex. “Make me come . . .”

Lip Service

Steve was on a solo mission, laying down an Urzikstan killstreak, Meyer standing behind the couch leaning with both hands on the back and giving unheeded advice. Josh was in the kitchen grabbing beers for everyone. He popped all three tops, eyes turned down waiting for his phone to display Kimmy's current location. Old habits die hard.

And yes, there Kimmy was, roughly in the same spot the last time he'd checked. Right by the Jumpstart Complex. What the hell was wrong with him? Why was he so convinced something was wrong?

Oh, probably because everything that has transpired up to this point. You remember Devlin taunting you, all that shit . . .

But it didn't amount to anything, did it? Kimmy was at the gym. This primordial worry, a premonitory sixth sense that was wrenching on him—it was just lying to him. It was nonsense fabricated by years of youthful torment at his ripening age when he was most sensitive.

You can see her pinging blue dot right there, Josh. And Kimmy would never cheat on you. You know it.

Meyer slid into the kitchen on sock feet, moving quiet. He eyed Josh, gave him a wink, then grabbed another bag of chips off the counter. He held them softly between both hands like he didn't want to crinkle them and make too much noise, coming to stand next to him at the pass-through, both of them watching Steve light up four terrorists with his modified M4A1.

Meyer said, "That's not really a thing, is it?—what he said." Meyer nodded his chin out toward Steve on the couch.

They both looked down at the phone, the obvious map showing its throbbing blue radar. He swiped the screen away, turned his phone over.

Meyer said, “You’ve gotta be kidding. Is it really a thing?”

“No,” Josh said. “It’s not. But it gets in my head sometimes because the guy she fought with was this guy that I hated in high school. Shit, he hated me more, that guy . . . not just in high school—all through public school, too. He’s a real asshole.”

“Kimmy wouldn’t do . . . that.”

“I know,” he said, “the guy just gets in my system.”

He considered divulging more, but there was too much shame involved. Devlin taunting him, coming in the tent and showing him his erection . . . He didn’t like the retelling of that story. Didn’t like how it framed him as this passive loser. Besides, it was crazy because Meyer was right.

Anything Devlin told you was a lie.

Just lay low, don’t fight back, keep it to yourself. Devlin will move on to something more entertaining if he can’t get a rise out of you.

Josh passed Meyer his beer, took his and Steve’s, jabbed the neck of his bottle against Meyer’s saying, “Let’s just drop it. You’re right and I know you’re right. It’s not about Kimmy, it’s about high school . . . and that was a long time ago . . .”



As Devlin’s fingers rhythmically thrummed between her legs, the touch driving her wild, she dug her heels on the footboard, pumping her hips

against his teasing, her body hungry for deep penetration. She sighed and gasped, the whole while a soft wet clicking from between her legs. A puffy cloud of condensation filmed across the passenger window; out the windshield oblivious traffic hissed left and right.

She gasped and moaned with his ministrations; every time the need grew great it was as though Devlin knew it, pushing two fingers deeper inside, giving her what she needed when she needed it. It was like sex. His hand large, two combined fingers as big as an erection.

While he pleased her, she'd worked her left arm into an awkward fold, and her hand up the inside of Devlin's thigh. She could feel the muscle under the wool fabric, the hardness of his long legs, her wrist now bumping against a softness. That would be his scrotum, bundled in the crotch of his expensive pants. A quick elbow jabbed up, and she was able to put her hand on it. Could feel now the softness in her clutch, not pliable really, but two moveable objects within. His naked scrotum would fill her hand.

Her wrist bone detected his hardness.

"Oh God," she sighed, knowing how wrong this was, knowing how bad; but it wasn't the worst thing. As Devlin said, everybody messes around, and this was just that: messing around. Playing. Just a little pleasure. Maybe some unfinished business . . .

His fingers moved faster while she squeezed his balls. Her breaths came in quick darts, soft whisk-whisking like someone tearing newspaper in short starts. Devlin grunted in her ear, going in time with her breathing, like they were syncopated together, doing this thing with each other. Quick wrist flip, and her hand landed across the long hard shape of his penis inside his pants.

"Oh my God," she whispered, "God, you're so huge."

His cock was bound under the fabric, rising from the softness of his scrotum in an arc over his hip bone, the end of it extending beyond. She stroked her hand awkwardly, not able to reach the tip, the part she knew would feel good for him. She scrunched closer, but the console prevented it, jabbing a white line of pain across her ribs. She brought a foot up, resting

the heel of a sneaker on his burgundy leather bench seat, spreading her legs wide for him.

“Deeper,” she told him, and he leaned over her, his cheek pressing her temple, stubble scratching, the smell of sandalwood and pine flooding her nostrils.

Arm hooked over, now instead of teasing he was driving those fingers in and out of her, hard and fast. She gripped his hardness mid-shaft, squeezed, not able to even get a grip on it. It was too large, constrained by the bundled fabric at his fly. And now all she could think of was the sparkling lights behind her eyes, a whirring, whooshing sound in her ears. Her hips drove up and down autonomously, her body knowing what it wanted.

“Yes, yes, oh yes,” she gasped and cried, the wet click clicking coming faster and faster and faster . . .

It finally got her over. She drew in a long swishing breath, thrust down with her heel and drove her hips and ass right off the seat. Devlin plunged as deep as his fingers would go, curled upward, prodding her front wall and setting off the liquid trigger that had her bucking. She twisted and writhed, tried to tear at his big hard cock but ended up with a handful of his inside pant leg instead, crying and wailing and fighting at her own lips to pinch off the loudness of her satisfaction.

Then that parrot-miming urge to pee was letting go, miming now the act of flux. She looked down, as the heel of Devlin’s hand wiggled and jiggled, his fingers deep inside her. Wetness squirted and spritzed around his hand. The sight of it, the sheer lunacy of what she did mated with the visual representation—a man’s ejaculate but from her own feminine body—drove her even higher. Her eyes went dim and gray, like standing up too fast. Sound closed off, and she was cocooned in cottony silence. All focus pointed on the sheer oceanic ecstasy between her legs.

“That’s it, come, come for me,” Devlin growled, each word emphasized as he jabbed into her deep. “That’s fucking it . . .”

He left her gasping; she kicked her heel out and collapsed noodle-like in his seat, his hand still inside her yoga pants. Her stomach heaved in and out, his fingers slowly pushing out of her body with her tightness; the wet giving no grip and expelling the large intrusion. Devlin let them slip, brought them out of her then massaged them on her clit, going clockwise in hard circles. Each time around got her jumping and hitching breath, her knees going up, a wild tickle racing through her brain. She started to laugh, closed her thighs against his hand.

They sat like that for minutes, his hand clasped between her legs and hidden inside her yoga pants, her laying there accepting what she'd done. For the second time, she'd allowed Devlin Stone to make her come. And here it was: world without end. No doomsday, no hand of God coming down to extinguish her. Traffic still passed left to right; oblivious. Nothing changed.

Just enjoy it.

She laughed again, still panting, trying to gather herself now. She tidied her hair, adjusted her top, both of them checking at the same time and finding her nipples still pressed out the sweater. They shared snickers.

“You’ve had some night,” he said.

“Yeah, I have,” she laughed, still smoothing her hair.

“This is what I mean, Kimmy. You’re going to take the job. We’re going to have fun. You’ll see . . .”

“Uh-huh,” she said, still looking out the window, her mind compartmentalizing her behavior. Putting things in boxes like Marie Kondo would do. This would be a box hidden within a box hidden within another box in the back of a drawer in a dresser in the closet. Something real, but something secret.

She caressed Devlin’s hand now, still half tucked inside the front of her tights. She rubbed her thumbs on the veins across the back of his hand, tickled her fingers up beneath his shirt cuff, squeezed. Head rolled his way,

she caught him staring at her profile, devilish smile poking up one half of his mouth. She whispered, “Are you going to take it out now?”

Together, she and Devlin got his fly undone, but his erection was too long to come out without unbuttoning his pants and undoing the belt. With the fly of his pants flapped open, he tugged down the front of his underwear, brought out his huge cock. It stood upright for half a moment, then fell heavily away to his left hip. She leaned over the console, her shoulder rubbing his arm, hand slipping up the inside of his thigh.

“I want to see it,” she said, a certain comfort now in accepting the truth. She did want this. What was she going to do, fight it forever?

Devlin began unbuttoning his shirt, and she ran her palm on the hot sticky belly of his erection. Ran it from the base where it poked up from the humped out waistband of his underwear, reaching across to get to the tip. It was twice as long as her open hand. Even near the head, she almost couldn’t close her fingers around it. She had long fingers . . .

She stroked downward, gripped the base and angled it up right. “God, it’s so huge,” she sighed, truly marveling at his endowment. She’d held it before, saw it briefly, even been presented with it in her hallway—but had never kept her eyes on it, never enjoyed exploring it.

It was more than twice as long as Josh’s, and so thick she didn’t know how he could have sex with a girl. The base of his cock was a veiny trunk she couldn’t grip around, her fingers and thumb an inch apart. “So big . . .”

Devlin opened his unbuttoned shirt, and she let his cock fall back against his hard hairy stomach. Now her hand stroked the angled edges of his muscular midsection. His skin was warm to her touch, lightly furred, all angles pointing toward the tight slit of his navel. Devlin worked out a lot. His body was incredible. Her hands stroked up, his cock riding over the back of her hand until she went to his chest, felt the muscle there, swirling around in big circles, thumb plucking at his nipples.

She said, “Tell me what you want . . .”

“Right now? . . .” He put a hand to her cheek, and she leaned into it, let him cradle her face. He stroked her lower lip with his thumb saying, “I want to come in your mouth.”

She hid her face away, stifling a bawdy chuckle. She thumped her fist onto his hard chest. “You’re such a pig.”

“Come here,” he said, weaving fingers through her hair, gripping it tight, forcing her to face him. “You have a perfect mouth. I love watching it when you talk. You won’t let me kiss it, but I want my cock in there.” The index and middle finger of his other hand pushed on her lower lip to get her teeth apart, and she allowed him to slip them into her mouth. She accepted the pads of his two fingers forcing over the slick curve of her tongue.

Now she was flooded with the smell of her own sexual arousal. These were the fingers he’d fucked her with. She sucked them.

Instant revulsion hit her, her stomach rolling over, flinching like it wanted to get away. Lurid awfulness of what was happening making her heart beat harder than ever. Her breath came through her nose in snorts.

She let him fuck her mouth now with his two big fingers. Tasting herself, smelling herself. Hating this, but liking it, too. Loving it. This was something Josh would never do. Something she’d never want him to do. But she loved it from a man like Devlin and she couldn’t help it.

She brought a knee up and over, shifting and pivoting in the seat, getting on her knees. She put her hands on him, one on his chest one on his thigh to steady herself, then leaned over the console. He supported her with his large hands, holding her in place while she got comfortable, kissing his chest as her hand stroked his cock.

“Yeah, you going to suck it?”

“Yes,” she whispered across his chest, watching the hairs bristle with her soughing admission. “I’m going to suck it . . .”

Her hand stroked down the base, then slipped underneath his underwear like he'd done to her. She found the hot sticky abundance of his huge scrotum, squeezed, felt his big testicles roll in her grip, one of them squishing out, its weight against the inside of her thumb. She kissed the underside of his cock, pressing her lips on the spot just below the arrowhead chin. With her left hand, she ran the palm over the muscles of his stomach, used a knuckle to lever upright his long shaft. It was lit in the light from his dash, its ripe edges gleaming, so outrageously large.

She tongued the glans, bathing it with the flat of her tongue, the point then tickling at the slit, angling her head to lick down the underside. It got Devlin groaning. He still held a handful of her hair, his grip tight, occasionally tearing small stitches of pain behind her ear . . .

Trial

The head of his cock was large enough to strain the muscles of her jaw as she opened wide. There was a click in her left ear, and with only a shallow mouthful her teeth already dragged his skin. He was too large to suck. She did what she could. Her grip stroked, coming up high to gather the wet from her mouth, swirling her head and gently bobbing. Her tongue worked, flattening against the swollen swooping topside shape of his large cock head. While she did, Devlin worked farther down the fly of his pants and his underwear, revealing even more of his manhood. Without the underwear's waistband scoring near the base of his shaft, he now looked truly huge. A bare naked cock, long, thick, uncovered from large swollen tip to big sagging balls.

Her hand stroked fully while she sucked. Up to her mouth, gathering saliva, stroking down, every fifth time going low enough to cup his heavy hanging testicles. The more she sucked, the more his scrotum tightened, two large balls hugged up against the wide hull of his huge cock.

She pleased him as best she could, closing off her mind to the awful act she did. It was sequestered; two people in private, just a bit of fun. Everybody messes around . . .

Devlin shushed her suddenly, his hand releasing the grip on her hair and cupping the back of her head—not trying to push her throat down onto him, not to stab his massive cock deeper into her face—he guided her against his belly until her ear flattened on his hard hairy stomach. She could hear his heartbeat, feel his pulse against her tongue. She made a questioning sound, her mouth still around his cock. He shushed her again, and now she raised her eyes, detected movement out the driver side window.

She hissed a surprised sound, tugged her head off him, her ear scratching along his muscle, and him pulling her up to hold her against his chest.

“Shit,” she hissed, looking out the window.

Devlin chuckled and grumbled, smoothed his hand down the back of her neck, and over her shoulder. Still he chuckled. It wasn't the car next to them where there was movement. Two down, taller than the cars, it was a minivan, two people, one getting in each side. There was a man on the far side, a woman nearer to them. A couple she recognized from the gym. Enough to say hello, though she didn't know their names. Maybe in their fifties, the woman sometimes showed up at yoga, the guy did elliptical and the treadmill, and she'd see him on the weight machines every once in a while too. They were making plans for a dinner party. Saying Well, so-and-so won't come, because they don't like Bruce . . . Now Kimmy was chuckling too, hiding away, having to hug herself flat against Devlin. He reached forward, cuddling her in his lap for a second, cranking a seat lever and sliding it all the way back now. They were out of view, both of them having to peep and spy the couple getting in their minivan.

He said, “The windows are tinted. They can't see us . . .”

“I kind of know them,” she said.

“Should I knock on the glass, see if they want to say hi?”

“Oh, I don't think you want to do that,” she said, sneaking her hand between his legs and giving his balls a threatening squeeze. They both snickered. She said, “Why are we whispering and laughing quiet?”

“Kimmy doesn't want to get caught,” he said, and his hand went from her shoulder down her rib cage, over her rump. The tights were still tugged down, her ass bare, and Devlin slipped his hand underneath. She leaned forward, her hand coming up to hold his cock, her face near the window. The older gym couple got in the vehicle and clunked their doors closed.

Devlin slid two fingers inside her again, getting her to gasp, then began pleasuring her while she slowly jerked him. The minivan's headlights came

on, lighting up long spotlights on the grassy barrier. “God,” he said, “your friends are taking forever.”

She pushed her butt back, wanting his fingers inside her saying, “They can take their time if you’re doing this.”

“You’re so wet,” he said, and he wasn’t kidding. She could feel it now, overflowing. What the hell had happened when she came? It was like she’d ejaculated. Her insides had gushed. It seemed like the liquid was still coming. “Mm, God,” she sighed, I think I’m going to come again.”

“Let’s get you there.”

“Why are they taking so long?” she grunted, eyes narrowed to thin lines, wet warbling her vision. At last, the headlights’ glare began to spread wide as the minivan reversed—and she came again. Like them backing up had pulled her trigger.

She gasped, and he plunged his fingers in and out, doing it fast, knowing somehow that was exactly what she needed right now. Her stomach bowed in and out, starlight flickered at the edges of her vision until she shut her eyes. Then it was just phosphorescent orbs floating around behind there, and she bit the inside of her cheek, holding it clamped, riding out the orgasm, not shouting out this time like she worried her gym companions in the minivan might still hear her.

“Kimmy,” Devlin said, slowing his stroke, then running his fingers over the creases of her opening, “God, you are so wet I can’t even believe it.” He ran the middle finger up high, slipped a circle around her anus, got her jumping and laughing, squirming out from his touch.

She eased back now, both of them alone in the cabin of the Mercedes again. She flicked her hair aside, looked in his eyes—then looked away. That was too personal.

He said, “You come again?”

“Maybe,” she lied. She came.

His hand went down her haunch, four flat fingers massaging against her opening, the middle one finding the protuberance of her hardened clit. He said, “I could get it in you right now.”

“Yeah,” she said, “maybe you could.”

“I know I could,” he said, teasing at her entrance, more than two fingers this time.

“Don’t,” she said, easing away from him. Then: “Let’s just make you come,” she said, on her knees, a hand against the back of his seat in the space between his shoulder and neck. Her right hand jerked his cock fast, sticky skin sounds from his bouncing balls. “You want to come?”

“Not yet,” he said, touching her neck. “Come up here.” With the hand on her rump, he hoisted her again. He had to be two-and-a-half times her weight, and strong, his hand on her bottom was able to guide her into his lap and she would’ve had to kick and scream to prevent it from happening. She tumbled forward onto him, complaining, and then alternating with laughter. “What are you doing?”

“Sit in my lap, jerk me off.”

“That’s what you want?” she said. “God—my tights are cutting into me . . .”

“Take them down,” he said.

“I’m going to pull them up.”

“Take your tights down,” he said, big thumbs on both sides of her hips tucking into her waistband pulling her tights down.

“I’d have to get off again . . .”

“Just lift your knee . . .”

They fought and struggled, her wanting her tights on, him wanting them off. In the end, he won. Half won. Her tights and panties remained on one leg,

Devlin tossing one of her sneakers back to the footwell on her side. Her knees straddled the raised lips of the burgundy bucket leather, on the outsides of his thighs while she faced him.

She sat back, more space in the cabin now with his seat cranked rearward, the back levered down a few degrees. More upright, the steering wheel pressed against her lower back. If anyone were passing and could actually see him past the tinted windows it would look like she was in there by herself, sitting backward. They'd wonder what she was doing. Or assume she was sitting on the driver. But they couldn't see in, anyway . . .

Though the windows blocked the view from outside, they let light filter in. It fell in smoky purple across Devlin's bared chest and stomach, his enormous cock laying up on his belly angled slightly to the right. "Look at your body," she said, resting both palms just under his chest, feeling his muscle, the warmth of his skin, the hardness too. "Shoot, how much do you work out?" She massaged his hard chest . . .

"Not that much."

"I go three times a week and I don't look like this."

"You look perfect, Kimmy," he said, then tried tugging her sweatshirt upward. She thrust her elbows down to pinch it in place.

"Don't," she said, "I don't want to be naked."

"You are naked," he said, dropping a hand and touching her bare pussy.

"Shit," she said, "mm, when you touch me . . ." Practically moaning.

"You like it, huh?" Two fingers teased at her.

"I like it," she whispered.

With his hands on her hips, his big fingers digging into the softness of her ass, he eased her forward, that wide cable running up the belly of his cock grazing against her sopping wet sex.

“Ooh,” she moaned, then made a small laugh and covered her mouth.

He held her waist, thumbed the flat of her stomach. She began to hump her sex against the bare underside of his huge cock. “That’s it,” she said, “don’t move . . .” Still humping.

“You gonna come from that?”

“Shh,” she said shushing him, closing her eyes—then opening them, looking at his muscles, running her fingernails over his hard stomach, looking at the size of the thing laying on it. Biting her lip, imagining it inside her . . .

“Try it,” he whispered.

“No . . .”

“Just see . . .”

“No way . . .”

He slipped a hand underneath her sweatshirt, palmed her left breast, hard nipple poking through her bra and rubbing against his palm. “Mm,” she groaned, “squeeze . . .”

He did, gripping her itty bitty, massaging the flat against her hardened bud. She humped faster against his cock, her pendulous arcs growing more pronounced. Sliding her opening from his testicles midway up his shaft. Then back again. Forward. Back. Farther up.

Devlin thumbed his erection slightly upward. She dragged her greasy groove right up his shaft till she felt the pronounced bulb end of him press against her opening. He squeezed his ass muscles upward, putting pressure against her aperture.

“No way,” she laughed, sliding right back down to his balls again, sitting on them and squashing them.

Devlin said, “We don’t have to do anything. I just want to be inside you.”

“I told you I was ovulating,” she said, running her hair back from her face and holding her neck.

“That was last week.”

She chewed her lip. “But still . . .”

“Wish we had condoms.”

An honest and accidental admission: “I have condoms.”

“You do?”

“Whoops,” she said, covered her mouth with both hands.

Devlin said, “You bring condoms to the gym?”

“No,” she said. But in her purse was the three-pack of Magnums she’d bought on a fun whim. Now down to two after she’d used one on that enormous cucumber, pleasuring herself. And looking now at the reddish-brown hot-flesh cucumber on Devlin’s stomach, the one in her kitchen wasn’t so impressive.

“Get it,” he said, clapping her thighs.

“I can’t,” she said.

“In your purse?”

“Yeah . . .”

He sat up with her straddling his lap; she leaned her back against the steering wheel. He put an arm around the small of her waist, dipped the other arm into the passenger-side footwell and brought up her purse. He rested it on the console, tugged it open. She reached in, fished around until she found the lightweight cardboard box. Box flicked open, not wanting to draw it out where he could see, she tugged out two folded-over condoms and tore one off.

Laying back again, he saw the reflective gold of the packet, said,
“Magnums? Kimmy came prepared.”

“Stop,” she said laughing then covering her mouth.

“You didn’t buy those for Josh.”

“Don’t say that. Don’t.”

“All right,” he said, turning his face away for a second and still smiling. He looked hot in the dramatic light.

“I can’t do it,” she said.

“We’re not fucking, Kimmy. You think it won’t go in, and I’m saying it will. It’s like you don’t think I’ve ever had sex before because my dick is too big . . .”

“Look at it,” she said, gripping it, holding it and wagging it at him accusingly. “It’s so freaking big.” She palmed it now, caressing from tip to base.

“Put the condom on.”

“I’m not doing anything,” she said, her fingers tearing the foil packet. She plucked free the rubber, stroked his cock, angled it upright. Reservoir tip squeezed, she used two hands to get it over the large shape of his cock head then roll it down his shaft. The Magnum petered out. “Wow,” she said, amazed by his size.

“We’re all safe now.”

“I can’t fuck you.”

“You don’t have to fuck me, Kimmy.”

“I’m not going to.”

“We’re not,” he said. “But try . . .”

She put her hands flat on the hardness of his bared chest, began stroking her sex up and down his latex-covered cock now. From base to tip, base to tip again. Base to tip . . . Leaning forward, tilting her pelvis, opening the angle of her entry to the direction of his shaft . . .

Tribulation

Devlin pushed his hips, the huge end of his cock prodding at her.

“Don’t,” she said and laughed, hitting his chest.

“I thought you were going to.”

“No, we can’t.”

“Suit yourself. We’re here; I’ve got a dome. Just try. Once in, once out. Show you we can do it.”

“No,” she said. “But yes, we can probably do it.”

“I’m not too big for you.”

“Yeah? What if you are?”

“We can just play, if that’s how you want it.”

She massaged his chest; his body was so hard and ridged. She said, “I want to come again. I’m so close. It’s right there . . .”

“All right,” he said, his hand going between her legs, beginning to finger her, not in her body, just massaging her clit, rolling around its hood, peeling the hood back and exposing it. It got her breath coming faster. The heat of his cock burned a line along the inside of her thigh. She rocked on his balls, then got her weight on her hands, began humping his shaft again while he pleased her clit. She leaned forward, farther, putting her face in the

hollow of his neck, smelling that sandalwood and lemon and pine. This time when his penis prodded at her opening she didn't buck away.

One of Devlin's hands went between them, the other around the back, angling that monster upward, pushing at her, pushing, pushing . . . Fingers of the other hand guided the head of his cock into her entryway.

"Oh, oh shit," she sighed now.

"Go slow . . ."

"God, you are so big."

"You're so wet."

"I've never been so wet . . ."

It was hard to believe how she'd over-lubricated. Like her body knew her mate had a big one.

"There," he said, the head of his cock firmly seated in her pussy's foyer. "Ease yourself back. Take your time."

She did. Her elbows against his chest, eyes peeled up to the blackness of the Mercedes roof, sighing, "God, why are you so big?" then shifting downward, easing back. "Mm, it hurts . . ."

"Go easy."

She grimaced, his cock going into her body feeling far too large and far too foreign. Not right at all. Latex crinkled in the tightness of her grip on him. "It's in," she said.

"It's hardly in. Ease back more."

"It's . . . so big . . ."

"Does it hurt?"

She dug her nails into his chest muscle. “It’s good,” she admitted.

His fingers stroked upward, along his shaft up over her anus, getting her stomach fluttering. It tightened her stomach wall against his girth, provoking a bright tearing feeling at her perineum that was at once painful and yet sensual. “Wow,” she whispered.

“Easy . . .”

“Okay . . .” She sat back further, and sure enough, despite his massive girth, her canal began to swallow him. His oversized penis—hard as steel, throbbing—began entering her body. Not deep, not deep at all, but making its presence very much known. “Oh wow,” she gasped. Her insides seemed to gulp at him the deeper he got.

Devlin grunted, “You are tight.”

“Ow, mm...”

“Fuck, Kimmy, your pussy’s so good . . .”

“You like it?”

“I love it,” he said, hands caressing her thighs.

“Don’t go deep, please.”

“Take your time . . .”

And with that assurance, his hands slipped underneath her bell-bottomed sweatshirt, under her tee as well, big hands smoothing her flat stomach, warm against her skin. They swooped rearward, headed to unhook her bra.

“Not here,” she said. Saying it got her moving back, more upright, headed out of his grasp. “Oh wow, oh ow,” she said, the act getting Devlin deeper inside her.

“That’s good,” he groaned.

“Yeah, that’s good,” she sighed, finding it hard to breathe. She’d draw in, hold, gasp, hitch again. Her hand went to her stomach, ran circles like she could soothe the discomfort. Lower lip held under her front teeth, she listened to the wet sounds as Devlin crept deeper and deeper, her bodyweight settling in his lap, her wetness allowing his passage. Her hand went down, felt around where they were connected. “You’re not even all the way in,” she moaned.

“Fuck, you feel good . . .”

“Yeah, ah, you feel, mm, good too . . .”

She braced hands on his abs, not wanting him any deeper. It felt like he was in her guts, already deeper than she’d ever had a man. That stretching feeling was awful but somehow she loved it anyway, loved the feeling of having her sex claimed by dominant manhood. Another gasp, and she reeled rearward until her back lay on the Mercedes’ steering wheel. She rested there, insane high-pitch pleasure ripping between her legs. Her breaths came hard and fast. She rubbed her stomach low, right around where Devlin’s cock head felt like it might be. Hips swiveled. He drove up; she rose to resist his entry.

“No, don’t, that’s all I want, oh God, oh . . .”

A sudden burst of pleasure like squashing an over-ripe sweet and seedless grape—Devlin’s thumb mashed on her aching bulb of a clit. She hissed out loud like she’d been scalded, her fists thrashing down to strike her skinny thighs, bumping the bones.

“Oh God, oh my God, oh God, oh God . . .”

“Yeah?”

“It’s gonna . . . oh, mm, I’m, ah, gonna come again, keep, ah, keep going . . .”

Hips rocking in a frenzy, her thighs and feet ached from keeping herself levitated above Devlin, not wanting that monster any deeper inside her right

now. She had enough already, enough to get her off like crazy . . .

She humped, he thumb-rubbed, they both gasped and panted. In less than a minute he had her on a knife edge of blackout pleasure. She crossed an arm over her face so he wouldn't watch her because he'd got her singing a warbling "oh-wha, oh-wha, oh-wha," a doo-wop that sounded like she was imitating an oncoming firetruck. It was frenzied. Leather creaked, cloth ruffled in quick zips, the latex condom crackled; she clamped teeth on her arm-flesh to stifle a wild cry. She came again. Came hard, thighs going to steel, her ass flexing, rising up off Devlin, feeling that slide—God, that slide—as his cock moved in her tight interior while she came . . .

Then off him she fell, collapsing on his chest, laughing, sobbing, bucking, jerking as each breath was like a tickle reflex. Every nerve between her legs jumped alive. Her ass muscles quivered, her thighs shook.

With each exhale she watched the hair on his chest ruffle. It was over . . . it was over, it had to be over before she went too far.

Both hands went down, gripped his cock and jerked up and down. Fast, fast, fast. Watching the thing in her small grip, the pucker and wrinkle of the reservoir tip, the way the head filled out the Magnum; the way the condom rolled just below the halfway mark; the way his balls jumped between his legs with her furious two-handed pumping. The slickness of her stroke came from a mix of condom lube and her own juices. The Mercedes stank like sex.

It would be so easy to go too far, to fuck him; she wanted to now. No, she wanted to earlier, too, she just had self-control. No more self-control . . . but she hadn't truly fucked him. Hadn't cheated—at least not all the way. "Come, okay?—come, come . . ." Translation: don't make me lay back and get fucked because I sure would let you; don't make me suck it, it's too much; don't ask to come in my mouth, I don't think I can do that right now . . .

"Take the dome off . . ."

"I don't want a mess . . ."

“Mm, fuck, it’s coming . . .”

“Come . . .”

If you come, this is just play, nothing more . . .

And he did. She bit his nipple. Bit it to stop herself from looking up and meeting his eyes, not wanting the intimacy. It would be easier if he was just a nice body and a huge dick and nothing more. So she clamped teeth on his nipple and he came that way while she watched; a lion grumble in his chest, right under her ear, her head riding up and down on the waves of his breath, then those abs flexed and heaved, deep divots on either side of his column of stomach muscles, the valleys between hipbones. His massive cock went iron in her two hands, stiffening and quivering and flexing in her grip; his hips stabbed upward in hard thrusts, and the end of his condom jumped and squirmed as he filled it with his semen. She squeezed, massaged, stroked, watched it fill, then overflow and begin to spread a milky bulge under his cock head.

Something about seeing his excitement spewed and collected in the condom made her feel good, some biological impulse of happiness, brain chemicals sending her messages of pleasure to have satisfied her man. She thumbed the gooey bulge, squeezing the thick shaft still, gently stroking, admiring his manhood while his breath roared in the ear cupped to his hard chest.

As her own heart rate abated that satisfaction she felt began to stretch like warm caramel into disappointment. A hand job wasn’t the best way to please Devlin. But for now it was what she would be willing to do. Maybe more. She could suck him. She could do that. She’d done it . . . Maybe she would allow him to come in her mouth. Devlin would like it. Had asked for it.

When was the last time you let Josh come in your mouth? Probably years. Fuck. Josh . . .

Head tucked down, she closed herself off from reality. Don’t look up and see who it was you just let put his cock inside you. A guy you didn’t like, a

guy your husband hates. Devlin wasn't that bad the closer you got to him, but still . . . he was Devlin Stone.

Before he could speak and remind her with his deep voice a real live human was in the car with her, she let her hand drift down, cup the weight of his emptied balls, stroke back up—the wetness on her hand was her insides, and she marveled again at how wet Devlin had got her—and began to work at removing the condom, keeping herself busy; don't let your mind examine what just transpired and don't let Devlin remind you by speaking . . .

It took two hands to get the rubber off him; even a Magnum was tight. Couldn't help herself: when it was off, she held it by the ring and let it dangle, eyes going up and down its length, feeling the pendulous weight of the large volume of semen he'd pumped into the reservoir.

Devlin eased the seat up, closing her in the decreasing space between the steering wheel and his chest.

“Let me get off,” she said.

“You already got off,” Devlin said, hugging an arm around her.

“Pig.”

Devlin laughed.

There was a pervasive post-coital intimacy she hated. They'd both come, both made the other one orgasm. It was too close to him and she had to get back to her side before he groaned and held her or tried to kiss her again. She hiked a leg over the console and heaved off him, elbow on his chest, her finger and thumb pinching the used condom. Devlin helped her with a hand on her waist, guiding her back to the passenger side. But her legs were shaky and weak, and she pivoted to collapse butt-first into the bucket. The condom left her grip.

“Shit,” she hissed, pulling back her hair and peering in the dark to see where it'd gone.

Devlin asked her what was wrong and she said, “I dropped the condom.”

“If you got come on my carpet you’re fired before you start.”

“I didn’t,” she said, but maybe she did. “Shoot, shoot,” she muttered, hand feeling around. “Can you turn on a light?”

Devlin was already doing it, and now the cabin of his Mercedes flooded in focused halogen. Before she spotted for the condom, she was checking herself, seeing what would be exposed to anyone walking on the sidewalk or wanting into one of the vehicles next to them, hand moving down to cover the naked patch between her legs. Saw the condom.

“Oh, fucking shit!”

It was on her leg, sticky latex clung to her tights, below her knee and along the side of her calf. Upside down. Devlin’s sperm gulping down her leg and almost inside her shoe. “Fucking, oh my God . . .”

Devlin was laughing next to her as she pinched it closed, peeled it off her leg, disgusted, mad, hating him laughing and saying, “It’s all over your carpet,” even though it wasn’t.

Devlin still laughed, leaning to open the glove box saying, “Not the first time I had to get my car detailed, Kimmy.”

She tied off the condom, holding her leg outward in the footwell, turning it so his semen wouldn’t drip or roll into her shoe. Devlin tossed a handful of paper napkins into her lap and sat back groaning a satisfied sound.

“It’s going in my shoe,” she complained, swiping with a wadded napkin. “It’s all over my tights . . .”

“And you wanted to keep the condom on me to stop a mess.”

“Why do you think this is funny?” Still swiping. Hard enough she was burning her skin with friction.

“How can you not think this is funny?”

She scoffed, looked his way. The guy lounged in his driver seat, elbow on the sill, looking at her smug, fly open, big brown shining cock upright from his lap and leaning heavy to one side.

Funny? She'd just fooled around with him. His sperm was all down her leg. What would she do with these tights now? Was she going to go home like this? "I didn't have sex with you." Total non-sequitur. An excuse when provoked with the evidence of his semen on her clothing.

"No, you didn't," he said. "We played."

"That's all we did," she said, like that meant anything.

"You can call it whatever you want. You're into semantics."

"I'm not into semantics," she said into the footwell, scrubbing with a new napkin.

"Did it get on my carpet?"

"No, your precious fucking car is safe," she said, scrubbing, dabbing.

"I still have to get it detailed."

"Why?"

"Your slippery little cooch all over my leather."

Anger flashed, but instead of rearing up and raging, she laughed. Inexplicable at first, then she realized his methods . . . And she wouldn't fall for it again.

"Now you're laughing," he said, amused.

"You can't manipulate me."

"No. Not now. Only when you were all jammed up fighting with yourself over how bad you wanted my cock."

“Right,” she said, “Sure.” She flopped back, winged the balled up napkin at his face. It hit his smiling cheek, Devlin not flinching, then rolled down to fall between his legs.

He snickered breathily through his nose and she couldn’t help smiling as she put the naked leg through her tights, pulled them up, digging her heels into his floor and snapping the waist in place. She sat back with a tremendous sigh and pulled her hair back, heart still pounding, staring at the still-oblivious traffic slipping left and right on Stinson.

“I’m going to have to go shower in the gym.” She smelled her hands. Latex and her sex. She rubbed her thighs, snapped a pinch on the tights. “I’m just going to throw these in the garbage.”

“My semen’s fine, I don’t have a disease or anything, Kimmy.”

“I mean I’m not bringing them into the apartment.”

“You can buy new ones when you get paid.”

She puffed a scoff of breath, still looking out the window. “What are you doing now?”

“Back to Kingston. Bed. Tomorrow’s a shit show, then I have to fly to Italy day after.”

“Fancy.”

“The industrial part of Italy.”

“Have fun.”

“Work, work, work. Call me when you talk to Josh.”

“I will,” she said, chewing her inner lip.

“He going to let you?”

“Take the job? I don’t know.”

“You’d be crazy not to.”

“I know,” she said, nodding.

“And next time, tie off the condom and don’t play around with it.”

She shook her head, chuckling. “Yes, sir,” she said with mock military compliance.

“Ooh, I like that,” he said.

“Yeah, you’d like it if I did everything you said.”

He chuckled now too, shifting in his seat and getting her to look his way. He touched her neck and she didn’t shy away. He said, “I would. But only because you’re not that kind of woman.”

“I’m not.”

He smiled slyly, eyes narrowing; he thumbed her lower lip.

Now she rolled her eyes and pulled away. Devlin watched her and she watched him. He thrust his hips up, tucked that huge softening cock into his underwear and zipped up. “You going to hit the showers?”

“Yeah,” she said, nodding, wiping her nose and gathering herself.

“You call me. If Josh says no, tell him he’s crazy. I was kidding about talking to him, but if I’m the problem I can talk to him, let him know I’ll be on my best behavior. If you think it’d help.”

“I don’t think he thinks about you,” she said, lying.

“That’s good.”

“And what’s this about you being on your best behavior?”

“Oh, I’d be fucking lying,” he said and laughed. She reached across and tweaked his nipple. Held it. They both watched her hand touching him. The

hand loosened, lay flat, smoothed over his bare chest.

“We can still get that room,” he said.

She clucked her tongue, beat a balled fist lightly on his hard chest, whispered, “Pig,” and backed to her side. “I gotta go,” she said.

He eyed her, brows high, face happy. “Call me . . .”

All Apologies

Ten o'clock was the time he told himself he would worry, and now it was a quarter after.

Steve and Meyer were still engaged in Modern Warfare but he'd sequestered himself to the arm end of the couch and had checked out now for twenty minutes. Two hours would be a long time to be at the gym. Three hours was too long. Something had happened. There was a feeling in him, that sixth sense thing again. Something not right. A disturbance in the Force.

And now there was a worry that Steve and Meyer would notice her absence, especially after the earlier discourse about potential problems in his relationship with his wife. Wow, Josh, awful late for Kimmy to be out . . . she usually at the gym this long? "No," he'd say, "but it's probably all right." In juxtaposition with what had been said earlier, he would be ashamed in front of them.

And now a flash of anger.

Way to go, Kimmy. Even if you fell asleep on the elliptical, now you're going to be coming home to my friends who think you might've been up to something dirty. Something nefarious.

Six empty bottles of beer were his claim to fame tonight—two on the coffee table, four more on the kitchen counter. The booze was a consoling friend. His mind tormented by his wife, by the texted taunts of his high school bully, and the phantom man who'd appeared inside his tent. Was that even real?

Of course it was real, the texts, Josh, he sent you the text. The text didn't say he was in the tent. So what? For fuck's sake . . .

Surreptitiously, he checked his phone again. He'd been avoiding using the app to locate Kimmy because it was a terrible state of mind to put yourself in. But it was 10:15 now, an unusual time for her to come home from the gym, and any normal non-suspecting husband would also want to see if his wife was okay . . .

Fucking right here. Blue pinging dot emanating right outside their address, her dot practically overlapping his dot.

He closed off the phone, cursing himself, cursing the weakness of his own mind. She was home. 10:15. It's not like it's two in the morning. She left at what—seven? Three hours at the gym? Maybe she took a class, maybe went spinning, perhaps an impromptu yoga session.

Maybe she'd met up with Devlin in a hotel room and fucked for three hours. Maybe that was tonight's workout. Would she leave her phone at the gym? Maybe locked in her locker . . . ? He thumped a fist on his knee, grumbling and chewing the inside of his cheek.

Why would he think these things about her?

Meyer was looking over, looking at the fist still plopped on his knee. "What's up?"

Before he could answer, the front door was opening, Kimmy coming in, the sound of her gym bag being thrown to the floor with a quiet whomp, door closing, keys jingling, latch turned to lock. It was another moment before she appeared in the doorway, gym bag held against her stomach, looking bright but noticeably breathless. She scanned the backs of Steve's and Meyer's heads, then watched the TV screen. Didn't even look his way.

Game paused, Meyer hooked an arm around the back of the couch. "Hey, Kimmy, just in time to show Steve how this is done."

Steve scoffed, said, "Yeah, right," turned and nodded to Kimmy.

She said, “You guys still playing games?”

Meyer held up the controller in offer. “You want in?”

She said, “Where’s Sophie?”

Meyer said she was in their bed and Kimmy cocked her head, made an affectionate “Aw.” Finally her gaze oscillated toward him. Their eyes met and there was a small spark. Nothing bad glimmered. Kimmy smiled and waggled her fingers at him.

“Hey,” he mouthed, then cleared his throat and spoke louder: “Kinda late.”

“Yeah, sorry,” she said, dipping back into the hall and slinging away her gym bag like she didn’t want to have to go into the bedroom to return it and wake Sophie.

When she reappeared, Steve was at her defense. “I don’t blame her. Why the heck’d she want to be here with a bunch of dudes playing video games, farting up this place like a frat house and drinking too much beer . . . but you’re welcome to join us, Kimmy. Grab a beer, and if you feel like it toss up your leg and let it rip. We weren’t shy when you weren’t around . . .”

“Steve,” Kimmy laughed, “you’re so gross,” then came around the couch, pausing at Josh’s shoulder, touching fingertips near his collar and dipping down to give him a kiss.

She smelled like soap and toothpaste and a touch of perfume. He laid his hand over hers, now a wavering orb of guilt radiating from his heart the way her Find My Phone dot had been throbbing on his screen. Why would you think such terrible things about her?

Devlin makes you. Devlin puts it in your head.

Now she came around, plopped beside him, squeezed between him and Meyer. She laid out a hand, and Meyer put the controller in it. “How do I work my thingy,” she said, nodding to the bobbing soldier on the screen.

Josh watched silently sitting right next to her, Kimmy's pretty profile going from controller up to screen, back to controller, thumbs working clumsily over the buttons. Later shaking the controller in frustration, gasping with anger when things weren't going right and she was getting shot up like a rookie to Steve and Meyer's laughter. Josh alternated from smiling to careful scrutiny. Studying her. Looking for signs.

Signs of what?

Don't let Devlin get in your head.

He stroked her thigh, pushing away those bad thoughts with a forced smile on his face, got closer, hip-to-hip and snaked an arm around her back. Kimmy leaned into it, cuddling against him, controller held up close to her face, jabbing thumbs, laughing and enjoying herself while the guys made fun of her.

When it was time for the guys to leave half an hour later, Kimmy told Meyer she'd go wake Sophie.

Josh was a minute behind, coming into the bedroom to see Kimmy sitting bedside shushing him, a finger to her pouted lips and telling him to be quiet.

Sophie lay curled on their still made-up bed underneath a pale yellow fleece blanket. She was asleep still, little head dented in the center of his pillow, black hair fanned out around her. A thumb was tucked in her mouth. Kimmy lightly stroked Sophie's hair, tracing it back from her face. Her eyes looked wet and shining and her lips were tugged in an unflappable smile.

"What an angel," she whispered as he came and joined her.

He sat down, knee to knee with Kimmy, resting his hand on Sophie's little hip. He patted his niece, whispered gently, "Come on, little girl, your daddy's going home."

They watched together in silence as Sophie came awake with a comical look of easy bewilderment, then sitting up looking around and rubbing her

eyes. Both of them had the same dumb smiles. Their eyes met and he figured something was communicated there. This was what they both wanted, wasn't it?

Kimmy was in the bathroom, closed in there by herself, sink running and the sound of teeth brushing. Everyone had left, just the two of them alone now and it was late. Work tomorrow. Josh was opening and closing drawers, changing, tossing his dirty things into the hamper getting into pajama pants and T-shirt.

The tapping of the toothbrush against the sink edge, then Kimmy's voice coming through the door: "You guys have fun tonight?"

"Yeah," he said. "I needed a night like that."

"I'm glad," she said, more running water.

"What did you do at the gym?"

Still through the door: "Cardio. Weights. I did a Pilates class. Then I . . ."

A pause for more running water. He waited. It shut off. "I had a smoothie at the juice bar. I was on my phone, turned around and hit it with my elbow and put green tea and kale all over my leg. I had another shower, then I sat in the sauna for a bit."

"Then another shower after the sauna?" She would have been all sweaty . . .

"Yeah."

"That's a lot of showers." What the hell are you getting at?

The bathroom door opened, Kimmy flicking the light off. He darted eyes up, frightened like he'd been caught, like she'd opened the door and caught a glimpse of his thoughts as though they were playing out like shameful porno on his laptop screen. He jumped.

But now his eyes traveled his wife's body. Her black hair had been pulled from her face, completely revealing it, tied back in a tail. She wore something new. A black robe thing, his mind catching up and saying wait, it's a kimono. Black silk, satiny, shimmering in the light from their bedside table lamp. It was short, tied at the waist, a blossoming rose at her ribs. His eyes traveled lower, looking to her bare legs. They weren't bare. Or they were . . . But they were dull gray in color, a thin stitched band over her toes. Stockings?

Without faltering, Kimmy moved from the bathroom door and came to stand before him.

"What's this?" He touched the sleeve of her kimono, the fineness of the fabric slippery under his thumb.

"You like it?"

"I do," he said. "When did you get it?"

"Couple days ago."

"It's beautiful," he said, then thinking Too beautiful for our plain old bedroom. She looked incredible, like she could get paid to model it.

She slipped hands under his arms, touching his waist and getting his stomach fluttering, hugging herself to him, and laying her cheek on his collar. "I love you," she said.

He put his arms around her, held her. "I love you too."

Face turned against his neck, she kissed him below his ear. She whispered, "I don't want to stress you out with dirty talk . . ."

"You didn't stress me out," he said, showing an awkward smile to the ceiling. His hands dropped to the slimness of her waist.

She said, "So let me do the dirty talking."

"Oh yeah?"

Up on tiptoes, her lips touched his earlobe. She whispered, “I’m going to suck your cock.”

His stomach jumped in two tight bounces, Kimmy’s words completely unexpected. With the mention of dirty talk he’d thought it was going to be about how they were going to roll around on the bed and the things she wanted done to her. “What?”

She’d dipped down to her heels again but bounced back up on her toes. Lips on his earlobe, she cupped a hand against his ear (like this addition would be terrible if it were overheard). “And you’re going to come in my mouth.”

“Hoo . . . what . . .?”

Back down on her heels, she kissed his T-shirt above his heart, ran her hands up and down his shoulders. He held her still, cupped a hand behind her head, wanting to see her face. He guided her to look at him. Her eyes were still wet, her smile hesitant. “I love you,” she said again.

He kissed her, and she kissed him back; they held each other’s necks while they did. Then she was guiding him backward, and he was going.

More guilt—maybe because of the terrible things he’d thought of her earlier, or maybe just a generalized guilt over receiving pleasure without reciprocation—made his mind race to offer up alternatives that would be for them together, show his consideration for her: “Do you want to get on the bed?— Do we have condoms?”

She said, “We don’t need condoms tonight.”

“But I thought we were waiting. You just started the pill again . . .”

She sat him down, put her hands on his shoulders and looked in his eyes. “You’re going to come in my mouth.”

And now he was frozen. Jaw immobilized. Stunned like she just flashed high beam lights in his face. It was that lawyer Kimmy. That mean one, the one you couldn’t read. But there were cracks in the facade. What was

shining through those cracks wasn't high intensity lumens, it was glowing like warm ardor. Like she really wanted to do this for him because she loved him.

He said nothing, stared at her stunned. She smiled sideways, displaying a momentary look of trepidation. Then stood, hands undoing the knot on the kimono's belt. It opened, she thrust it backward and it fell soundless around her heels.

“Holy . . .”

Again, speechless. Kimmy, his wife, in black lingerie . . . black triangles over her breasts, black panties with smoky jade-colored roses done in ruffled embroidery. And a garter belt. A real live garter belt like she was out of a Playboy magazine he found in his grandpa's brother's attic when he was little. From the garter belt, straps extended down to hold a pair of stockings mid-thigh.

His hand went out like he was still that little boy in the attic finding that wondrous magazine, touching his fingers to the image of his first naked woman. Touched her hipbone, fingertips gliding along her thigh to touch the stocking. She'd struck him completely dumb.

Kimmy slapped his hand, and when he looked up she admonished him. ‘No touching.’

His stomach did that bounce thing again, and he swooned. Hands out behind him, he leaned his weight back. Kimmy dipped forward and ran a knee on the underside of his erection that had tented upward the crotch of his pajama pants. He let out a moan. She stroked her knee on the underside of his hardness, then gradually lowered, got down right between his open legs at the side of their bed, and his heart raced and pounded in his ears, a herd of horses thundering over the plain . . .

Hands tucked into his waistband, she worked the pants downward, snagging them on his upright erection, snapping it free and making it jitter, him lifting his butt off the bed, putting his weight on his hands. She pulled them

down, and he was awkward kicking his legs around, trying not to knock her over when she was so low to the ground.

And there he was, wearing just a T-shirt, pantsless, legs open, his incredibly beautiful wife between his knees running her warm hands up and down his naked thighs.

“It’s beating,” she said, studying his erection. He looked down, could see it bobbing with his heartbeat.

“You’re so hot,” he said.

“Thank you,” she said, hands coming up to touch his hipbones, getting closer and closer and closer . . .

Completion

First thing she thought—and hated herself for it—was how easy Josh went down. She took him to his base with no warmup, his pubic hair scratching her nose. Try as she might, she couldn't help an awful phrase from blossoming up from the base of her brain: Double-A.

What helped was total devotion to giving her husband oral pleasure. The more guilt rolled her way, she could upend the table, send the ball back where it came from by enthusiastic throat sounds, vigorous bobbing, squeezing on his balls. And she was rewarded. Josh made gasps of pleasure that tickled her heart, made her feel so good. Why hadn't she done this for him more regularly?

And forget that Double-A stuff, anyway. Josh had a normal penis. Not every man had what Devlin had. Josh was as large as a guy should be. It's what made Devlin special. He wouldn't be special if Josh had a giant dick too. Devlin was more than a giant dick—and that was okay too. She could do this maybe. Work for Devlin, make lots of money, travel . . . mess around. But just a little. Not all the way. Hands and mouth, maybe. Maybe a little more. And Josh would get all of her. She would give him her all, her real self. By day she'd be the lawyer, by night, she'd be with her husband, in love with him.

Now she hummed at the thought, getting her palette vibrating on the underside of his cock, figuring he'd like that, feeling real true love for her man, wanting him happy and satisfied. Josh's thighs shook against her forearms. She bobbed faster, saliva spilling and rolling over his scrotum . . .



Between his legs, Kimmy's head bobbed backward and forward, a wild and lubricious and stunningly wet feeling of sex along the entire surface area of his erection. Kimmy wasn't holding back. She was giving it her all. Rhythmic but unpredictable, her sucking had him trembling, shaking, his breath erratic.

He watched the movement of her shoulder blades, the sway of her hair, her perfect thin body strapped in black, his wife dressed up entirely for sex . . .

In only minutes she had him warning her: "Kimmy, mm, Kimmy, I think I'm gonna . . ."

He warned her again half a minute later. She didn't slow.

Now came a feeling of free-fall, like his stomach dropped, his balls went heavy but instead of hanging, their sudden weight pulled upward with the tightening of his stomach muscles as his seed boiled over and began its launch pattern.

Urgent hissing: "Kimmy, Kimmy . . ." Last chance, Kimmy, oh God, I can't believe this . . .

And Kimmy didn't pull away, hugged her face to his crotch, hands grabbing at the small of his back, every inch he had impaled deep in her face. Hands cupped on her head, her silky hair on his palms, he seized, restricting his urgent desire to thrust and stab as he ejaculated, instead sitting, scalp tingling and peeling, all throbbing nuclear fusion focus on the hard muscle under his balls as it squeezed into a knot and his seed exploded down Kimmy's throat. Pulse after pulse, his chest tight, breath held, then a chuffing exhale, body jolting from electric bolts of white pleasure as her slippery mouth moved against his ramrod of a cock. "Oh Kimmy, oh Kimmy . . ."

He babbled as pleasure worked to obliterate his mind; a disbelieving unreality to this situation. Too good to be true was what he thought. Coming in his wife's mouth hadn't seemed like something he needed in his life until he was doing it. That she would want to do this for him without him even asking had him breaking for her, wanting to sweep her up and hold her tight, show his affection and undying love. He displayed his appreciation with bellows of satisfaction, his hands on the side of her head, feeling the small hard shapes of her ears under the softness of her hair.

They stilled finally, him huffing, Kimmy's breath snorting through her nostrils, his cock still in her mouth. They both began chuckling at the same time. Kimmy took her time removing her mouth from him, inch by inch slipping backward, squeezing with her lips like she wanted every last drop. He couldn't even believe it. He'd never seen her in such a sexual light.

She hid her face in her hair, up on her toes but still squatted, wiping at her mouth before rising to stand, her hard stomach and tight navel in his face. She laughed, then ruffled his hair.

In breathy bewilderment, full of appreciation: "Holy shit, Kimmy, what the heck was that?"

She laughed again, pulled her face away, and he grabbed her wrist, tugging. She fell to sit on his lap, her naked butt cheeks on his bare thighs, her panties some kind of thong back. He said, "What is going on?"

"Did you like that?"

"Oh my God, I . . . I still can't believe that . . ."

"Was it good?"

He hugged her, so wild still he was temporarily wowed out of speech. "Kimmy, Kimmy," he sighed.

She slunk out of his lap and stood. Indeed a thong back. Or at least a high scoop. Was her ass always this perfect? Like she knew he watched, her

hands came to hide her ass, and she pivoted aside, and scooped up her kimono.

“Hey, don’t get dressed,” he said.

“I have to get in my PJs,” she said.

“PJs? Why don’t you come to bed,” he said, patting the spot next to him, his other hand covering his depleted erection.

“I’m coming,” she said, “Let me get my PJs on.” She sashayed into the bathroom again leaving him there unsure, her smoky stocking legs dancing in then closing the door behind her. On the one hand, he was beyond satisfied and grateful that she’d done that for him; on the other: didn’t she want her turn?

He got up, pulled on his own PJ pants, moved nearer their bathroom door saying, “Want me to go down on you?” Then the words out in the air, he felt silly.

“What?—no, I’m fine, I’ll be out in a sec, hold on . . .”

When she was out, he was waiting for her, taking her in his arms. Gone was that mirage of his hyper-sexualized wife, like he’d imagined it, and now she was how he knew her, wearing cotton bottoms with a drawstring waist and a too-big shirt that hid that lean and sexy frame. “I want you to have your turn,” he said.

“It’s all right, Josh,” she said, smoothing hands on his chest. “I just wanted to do that.”

“Why?”

She laughed, squeezed out of his grip, but pulled him toward the bed.

“Why? Why wouldn’t I? You just wanted to give me my turn. Why?”

“I want to . . .”

“Is it so crazy I wanted to do that?” She crawled to her spot on the bed on all fours and he stood there watching.

“You don’t want anything else?”

Now it was her patting the spot next to her, inviting him into the bed. “I want to sleep, and I want you to cuddle with me.”

“Jesus,” he said, scratching his head, coming around to his side to climb in with her, Kimmy holding up the sheets. “What did I do? How do I get so lucky?— Playing video games all night, pizza and beer—”

“With your buddies.”

“With my buddies, and then my wife—who’s hotter than ever, I mean it—comes home and does . . . that . . .”

She smiled, patted the spot next to her again. “Now she wants to cuddle . . .”

When he’d slipped in, she’d got her arms on him, pulling him into place and now they were spooned, her chest to his back. The light was still on and they lay with each other, bodies breathing in rhythm.

Her hand was on his chest and he took it now, kissed her fingers, wedding ring poking the side of his nose. “Sophie’s such an angel,” he said.

“She is,” Kimmy sighed, kissed the back of his ear. “We should have her and Meyer over more.”

“He’d like it. And I like seeing Sophie.”

She kissed his ear again. He hugged her hand.

She said, “I think I’m going to go back to work.”

He nodded, a mild wave of disappointment rising up. “Okay.”

“Is it okay?”

“If you want to go back to work, Kimmy, I want that too.”

“You know why though, right?”

“Money.”

“I can’t stagnate, Josh. Once I have kids am I ever going to go back to work?”

“Kids, plural?”

“Maybe.”

“I’d like that,” he said, smoothing the back of her hand. Picturing it now. Two Sophies, maybe a little boy. “I know.”

“I might have a narrower window.”

“We’re doing all right.” They had a nice palette of cash in the bank, saved for their future, living frugally.

“We are. Say I go back to work, not the firm, but take something better . . . in a few years . . .”

“I’ve thought about it. You have too?”

“Been thinking about it. I’d like to have a house.”

“So would I . . .”

“I should go back to work. Don’t you think?”

“Kimmy, the decision is yours, you know that.”

“I want your opinion. What do you think?”

“Both of us working was hectic. But, I know, you must get bored around here, like . . .”

She sighed, “I can’t make any more baskets . . .” They both chuckled.

“Go to work, Kimmy. Whatever makes you happy. We can put off a family a little more. As long as you still want kids . . .”

“Of course.”

“Then go back to work,” he said, rubbing a thumb on her wrist. And knowing it would come up, he made the first strike: “That thing for Devlin Stone for real?”

“I don’t know. Maybe.”

He scoffed.

She flicked his earlobe making him flinch. He chuckled.

They were quiet for a moment before she said, “What would you think?”

“What do you mean—working for Devlin?”

“Yeah.”

“I don’t know. I wouldn’t like it.”

“What if it was a lot of money?”

“Yeah? How much is a lot of money?”

“I’m not sure. I think I want to find out.”

“How much would it take for you to work for that asshole?”

“I don’t know. How about for you?”

No hesitation: “Ten times.”

Kimmy laughed against his back, hugged him tighter. “I guess it’s off.”

He shook his head, rolling his eyes. “No. Sorry. I don’t know. Two times? If it paid two times what your other firm paid, I guess . . .”

“We could buy a house in a few years.”

“That would be so awesome,” he said, nodding now.

She said, “Should I find out what he’d offer?”

“I guess. Yeah, okay. No harm in that . . .”

She gave no reply, left him a moment to turn over and switch off the light. Returned to him though, put her arm around him again, scratched nails on his chest.

But he couldn’t help wondering if working for Devlin was what the blowjob was about.

Then cursed himself for such a vile thought.

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